

The Tao that can be spoken of is not the Tao itself. The name that can be given is not the name itself. The unnameable is the source of the universe. The nameable is the originator of all things. Therefore, oftentimes without intention I see the	A tao that can be spoken about Is not the constant Tao; A name that can be named Is not the constant name. Nonbeing names The ten thousand things' beginning; Being names The ten thousand things' mother. Therefore, constantly be desireless,	The way that can be spoken of Is not the constant way; The name that can be named Is not the constant name. The nameless was the beginning of heaven and earth; The named was the mother of the myriad creatures. Hence always rid yourself of desires in	Reason's Realization The Reason that can be reasoned is not the eternal Reason. The name that can be named is not the eternal Name. The Unnamable is of heaven and earth the beginning. The Namable becomes of the ten thousand things the mother. Therefore it is said: "He who desireless is found	Direction, as expressed, is no ordinary direction; as named, no ordinary name. Null identifies the universe at the beginning. Ull identifies the mother of myriad matters. Thus, visit Null to observe
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wonder of Tao. Oftentimes with intention I see its manifestations. Its wonder and its manifestations are one and the same. Since their emergence, they have been called by different names. Their identity is called the mystery. From mystery to further mystery: The entry of all wonders!	Whereby to observe its minutiae; Constantly be desirous, Whereby to observe where it ends. The two issued from the same origin, And, though different in name, Refer to the same thing. Deep and remote, doubly deep and remote, Gate of multitudinous minutiae.	order to observe its secrets; But always allow yourself to have desires in order to observe its manifestations. These two are the same But diverge in name as they issue forth. Being the same they are called mysteries, Mystery upon mystery - The gateway of the manifold secrets.	The spiritual of the world will sound. But he who by desire is bound Sees the mere shell of things around." These two things are the same in source but different in name. Their sameness is called a mystery. Indeed, it is the mystery of mysteries. Of all spirituality it is the door.	its intricateness. Visit Ull to observe its limitlessness. These two spring from the same source; only their identifications differ. Both are profound. Profound upon profound, it is the portal to all intricacies.
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When beauty is universally affirmed as beauty, therein is ugliness.

When goodness is universally affirmed as goodness, therein is evil.

Therefore: being and non-being are mutually posited in their emergence.

Difficult and easy are mutually posited in their complementariness.

Long and short are mutually posited in their positions.

High and low are mutually posited in their contradiction.

When all under heaven know beauty as beauty,

There is ugliness;

When all know goodness,

There is evil.

That being and nonbeing mutually generate,

Difficult and easy mutually complement,

Long and short mutually formulate,

High and low mutually fulfill,

Music and voice mutually harmonize,

Front

The whole world recognizes the beautiful as the beautiful, yet this is only the ugly;

the whole world recognizes the good as the good, yet this is only the bad.

Thus Something and Nothing produce each other;

The difficult and the easy complement each other;

The long and the short off-set each other;

The high and the low incline towards each other;

Note and sound harmonize with each other;

Before and after follow

Self-Culture

Everywhere it is obvious that if beauty makes a display of beauty, it is sheer ugliness. It is obvious that if goodness makes a display of goodness, it is sheer badness. For "To be and not to be are mutually conditioned.

The difficult, the easy, are mutually definitioned.

The long, the short, are mutually exhibitioned.

Above, below, are mutually cognitioned.

The sound, the voice, are

For [people in] the world to know [only] beauty and what is beautiful is ugly;

to know [only] goodness and what is good is not good.

Ull and Null complement in generation,

difficult and easy complement in completion;

long and short complement in form,

high and low complement in norm;

voice and sound complement in harmony,

front and rear complement

in their unity.

Front and back are mutually posited in their succession.

Thus, the wise deals with things through non-interference and teaches through no-words.

All things flourish without interruption.

They grow by themselves, and no one possesses them.

Work is done, and no one depends on it.

Achievements are made, but no one claims credit.

Because no one claims credit, achievements are always there.

and back mutually follow

Is constant.

Hence, the sage man

Assumed the office of nonaction,

Conducted speechless instruction.

When the ten thousand things rose,

He did not initiate.

He assisted without taking credit;

Scored merits without claiming.

Precisely because he claimed not,

They never vanished.

each other.

Therefore the sage keeps to the deed that consists in taking no action and practises the teaching that uses no words.

The myriad creatures rise from it yet it claims no authority;

It gives them life yet claims no possession;

It benefits them yet exacts no gratitude;

It accomplishes its task yet lays claim to no merit.

It is because it lays claim to no merit

That its merit never deserts it.

mutually coalitioned.

Before and after are mutually positioned."

Therefore

The holy man abides by non-assertion in his affairs and conveys by silence his instruction. When the ten thousand things arise, verily, he refuses them not. He quickens but owns not. He acts but claims not. Merit he accomplishes, but he does not dwell on it.

"Since he does not dwell on it

It will never leave him."

in company;

- they are ever so.

Thus,

a sage practices laissez-faire governance and provides wordless instructions.

[A sage] neither interferes with myriad matters' generation,

nor takes possession of [their] cultivation,

nor expects approbation of [his/her] provision,

nor seeks acclamation for [their] accomplishments.

If no one esteems the best, men will be free from contention. If no one values the precious, men will be free from illegal gain. If men see nothing to desire, their minds will be free from confusion. Therefore, the wise guides men by relaxing their	Do not exalt talents So that the people will not contend; Do not treasure goods hard to come by So that the people will not steal; Do not parade enviable things So that the people will not rebel. Hence, when the sage man	Not to honor men of worth will keep the people from contention; not to value goods which are hard to come by will keep them from theft; not to display what is desirable will keep them from being unsettled of mind. Therefore in governing the people, the	Keeping the People Quiet Not boasting of one's worth forestalls people's envy. Not prizing treasures difficult to obtain keeps people from committing theft. Not contemplating what kindles desire keeps the heart unconfused. Therefore the holy man when he governs empties the people's hearts but fills their stomachs.	Where admiration is not bestowed upon the wise, the populace will not compete for recognition. Where premium is not placed on rare goods, the populace will not engage in robbery. Where desirable items are not on display, the populace will not be tempted. Thus, the sage governs by cleansing
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minds and keeping their bellies firm; By reducing their wills and letting their physiques become strong. He always frees men from the search for knowing and demanding. This means that the knower dares not act for the known. When action is through non-action, no one is uncultivated.	ruled, He emptied their minds, Filled their stomachs, Weakened their ambitions, Strengthened their bones. He constantly made the people Uncrafty and unlustful, And made them know not to be daring. He acted not, that is all. Thus, the state cannot but become well-ruled.	sage empties their minds but fills their bellies, weakens their wills but strengthens their bones. He always keeps them innocent of knowledge and free from desire, and ensures that the clever never dare to act. Do that which consists in taking no action, and order will prevail.	He weakens their ambition but strengthens their bones. Always he keeps the people unsophisticated and without desire. He causes that the crafty do not dare to act. When he acts with non-assertion there is nothing ungoverned.	[the populace's] hearts, filling their stomachs, taming their will, and strengthening their bodies - to induce the populace, in time, not to indulge in knowledge nor to cultivate avarice. So prepared, those with wisdom dare not offer schemes, and laissez-faire governance follows. With that, no affair is beyond governance.
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Tao functions
through its
nothingness.

And can not be
conceived of as full
of things.

Profound indeed, it is
the model of all
things.

Dulling its sharpness,
Releasing its

The Tao is the empty
space of a vessel,
Yet, when used,
Never brims over.

How deep,

Like the ten thousand
things' progenitor!
It files its sharpness,
Unravels

The way is empty,
yet use will not drain
it.

Deep, it is like the
ancestor of the
myriad creatures.

Blunt the sharpness;
Untangle the knots;
Soften the glare;

Let

Sourceless

Reason is empty, but
its use is
inexhaustible. In its
profundity, verily, it
resembleth the
arch-father of the ten
thousand things.

"It will blunt its own
sharpness,

Will its tangles
adjust;

Direction is the
hollow.

Regardless of use, it
is inexhaustible.

So unfathomable, as
if the source of all

entanglements,
Tempering its light,
and

Unifying with the
earth,

Clearly, indeed, it
remains.

I do not know who
created it,

But it is likely that it
existed prior to God.

its entanglements,
Softens its
brightness,

And mingles with the
dust.

How transparent,
As if existing!

I do not know whose
son it was;

Seemed to precede
the Emperor.

your wheels move
only along old ruts.

Darkly visible, it
only seems as if it
were there.

I know not whose
son it is.

It images the
forefather of God.

It will dim its own
radiance

And be one with its
dust."

Oh, how calm it
seems to remain! I
know not whose son
it is. Apparently even
the Lord it precedes.

matters.

So deep, as if it
exists.

I do not know whose
offspring Direction
is;

it precedes kings.

Heaven and earth are not benevolent:

They treat ten thousand things indifferently.

The wise is not benevolent:

He treats men indifferently.

The entire universe is basically void, like a bellows:

When it is in non-action,

Heaven and earth are unfeeling,

Treating the ten thousand things like straw and dogs;

The sage man was unfeeling,

Treating the hundred family names like straw and dogs.

The space between

Heaven and earth are ruthless, and treat the myriad creatures as straw dogs;

the sage is ruthless, and treats the people as straw dogs.

Is not the space between heaven and

The Function of Emptiness

But for heaven and earth's humaneness, the ten thousand things are straw dogs. But for the holy man's humaneness, the hundred families are straw dogs.

Is not the space between heaven and earth like unto a bellows?

The universe is ignoble; it regards myriad matters as straw dogs.

The sage is ignoble; he/she regards the gentry as straw dogs.

Is

it does not lack anything;

When it is in action, it is even more productive.

Debating with words leads to limitations.

Therefore, nothing is better than to remain in the state before things are stirred.

heaven and earth -

Is it not like a bellows?

Empty yet inexhaustible.

The more it operates, the more it emits.

Much learning brings a quick end.

Better adhere to the middle.

earth like a bellows?

It is empty without being exhausted:

The more it works the more comes out.

Much speech leads inevitably to silence.

Better to hold fast to the void.

It is empty; yet it collapses not. It moves, and more and more comes forth.[But]

"How soon exhausted is

A gossip's fulsome talk!

And should we not prefer

On the middle path to walk?"

the universe not a wind tunnel?

Inexhaustible at rest; dynamic at its fiercest.

More rules yield faster demise.

Laissez-faire is a better device.

The spiritual reality
of the void never
ceases to exist.

We call it the
mystery of passivity.

The entry to

The valley spirit
never dies;

It is called the deep
and remote female.

The gate of the deep
and remote

The spirit of the
valley never dies.

This is called the
mysterious female.

The gateway of the
mysterious female

Is called

The Completion of
Form

"The valley spirit not
expires,

Mysterious woman
'tis called by the
sires.

The mysterious
woman's door, to
boot,

The valley is
undying.

It is the mystical
womb.

The portal to the
mystical

the mystery of
passivity is the origin
of the universe.

Unceasing, it always
remains.

Drawn upon, it is
never exhausted.

female

Is called the root of
heaven and earth.

Continuous and
unbroken, as if
existing.

When used, it is
inexhaustible.

the root of heaven
and earth.

Dimly visible, it
seems as if it were
there,

Yet use will never
drain it.

Is called of heaven
and earth the root.

Forever and aye it
seems to endure

And its use is without
effort sure."

womb is the root of
the cosmos.

Continuous and
unterminable, its use
is inexhaustible.

The existences of heaven and earth are long-lasting.

Their existences are long-lasting because they do not conceive of their existences as existences.

Therefore, their existences are

Heaven is permanent and earth, everlasting.

The reason why heaven and earth

Can be permanent and everlasting

Is that they do not live for themselves.

Therefore, they can live permanently.

Hence, the

Heaven and earth are enduring.

The reason why heaven and earth can be enduring is that they do not give themselves life.

Hence they are able to be long-lived.

Therefore the sage puts his

Dimming Radiance

Heaven endures and earth is lasting. And why can heaven and earth endure and be lasting? Because they do not live for themselves. On that account can they endure.

Therefore

The holy man puts his person behind and his person comes to the front.

The cosmos is long.

The earth is lasting.

The reason the cosmos is long and the earth lasting is that they exist not for self-perpetuation.

Unconcerned with self-perpetuation, they

long-lasting.

When the wise stays back, he steps forward.

When he forgets his self, he finds his self.

Is it not through selflessness that one achieves selfhood?

sage man

Withdrew himself to the back,

Yet found himself in front;

Cast himself aside,

Yet found himself preserved.

Is it not because he was selfless

That he could fulfill the self?

person last and it comes first,

Treats it as extraneous to himself and it is preserved.

Is it not because he is without thought of self that he is able to accomplish his private ends?

He surrenders his person and his person is preserved. Is it not because he seeks not his own? For that reason he can accomplish his own.

perpetuate.

Thus, the sage,

by queuing himself/herself behind others, ends in being ahead;

by being unconcerned, endures.

Is it not so that the sage, without self-interest, satisfies his/her self-interest?

That which is best is similar to the water. Water profits ten thousand things and does not oppose them. It is always at rest in humble places that people dislike. Thus, it is close to Tao. Therefore, for staying, we prefer a humble place.	The supreme good man is like water. Water is good at benefiting The ten thousand things without contending, Lying where the multitude loathes to: Therefore, close to the Tao. In habitation, He is good at choosing the place; In	Highest good is like water. Because water excels in benefiting the myriad creatures without contending with them and settles where none would like to be, it comes close to the way. In a home it is the site that matters; In quality of mind it is depth that matters;	Easy By Nature Superior goodness resembleth water. The water's goodness benefiteth the ten thousand things, yet it quarreleth not. Water dwelleth in the places which the multitudes of men shun; therefore it is near unto the eternal Reason The dwelling of goodness is in lowliness.	Goodness at its best is like water. Water benefits myriad matters but is not in competition with them. Water stays at a level disliked by others, as if it were the Direction. Wherever [the sage] stays, it is a good place; whatever [the sage] thinks, it is good
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For minds, we prefer profundity. For companions, we prefer the kindness. For words, we prefer sincerity. For government, we prefer good order. For affairs, we prefer ability. For actions, we prefer the right time. Because we do not strive, We are free from fault.	mind, Good at profundity; In giving, Good at imitating heaven; In speech, Good at honesty; In government, Good at bringing order; In duties, Good at exerting his ability; In making moves, Good at timeliness. Being uncontentious, There is no resentment.	In an ally it is benevolence that matters; In speech it is good faith that matters; In government it is order that matters; In affairs it is ability that matters; In action it is timeliness that matters. It is because it does not contend that it is never at fault.	The heart of goodness is in commotion. When giving, goodness showeth benevolence. In words, goodness keepeth faith. In government goodness standeth for order. In business goodness exhibiteth ability. The movements of goodness keep time. It quarreleth not. Therefore it is not rebuked.	thought; whomever [the sage] contacts, it is nobleness; whatever [the sage] expresses, it is truthfulness; however [the sage] governs, it is good administration; whatever [the sage] does, it is good deed; whenever [the sage] acts, it is timely action. Being not in competition, [the sage] has no concern.
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To hold things and to
be proud of them is
not as good as not to
have them,
Because if one insists
on an extreme, that
extreme will not
dwell long.
When a room is full
of precious things,
one will

To hold and fill it to
the brim -
You'd better stop it;
To hammer and
sharpen it -
You cannot long
preserve it;
To fill a room with

Rather than fill it to
the brim by keeping
it upright
Better to have
stopped in time;
Hammer it to a point
And the sharpness
cannot be preserved
for ever;
There may be gold
and jade to

Practising Placidity
Grasp to the full, are
you not likely foiled?
Scheme too sharply,
can you wear long?

Filling to the brim is
not as good as
stopping short;
Polishing to the
sharpest does not last
long.
A roomful of gold
and jade is

never be able to
preserve them.
When one is wealthy,
high ranking, and
proud of himself, he
invites misfortune.
When one's task is
completed and his
mission is fulfilled,
he removes himself
from his position.
This is indeed the
way of Nature!

gold and jade -
Nobody can
safeguard it;
To be noble, rich but
arrogant -
You will bring
yourself calamity.
To withdraw yourself
after scoring merits -
Heaven's Tao.

fill a hall
But there is none
who can keep them.
To be overbearing
when one has wealth
and position
Is to bring calamity
upon oneself.
To retire when the
task is accomplished
Is the way of heaven.

If gold and jewels fill
the hall no one can
protect it.
Rich and high but
proud, brings about
its own doom. To
accomplish merit and
acquire fame, then to
withdraw, that is
Heaven's Way.

hard to follow.
One prideful of
wealth and fame
sows the seeds of
sorrow.
With mission
accomplished, it is
time to offer
resignation.
This is cosmos's
Direction.

Can you unify hun and p'o into one and not let them be divided? Can you concentrate on your breathing to reach harmony and become as an innocent babe? Can you clean the dark mirror within yourself and let nothing remain there? Can you love the people and govern the state and do so without interference? Can you enter and	In making your soul embrace One, Can you keep it from departing? In concentrating your breath to make it utterly soft, Can you do so as an infant does? In cleaning and dusting the deep and remote mirror, Can you make it spotless? In loving the people and	When carrying on your head your perplexed bodily soul Can you embrace in your arms the One and not let go? In concentrating your breath can you become as supple As a babe? Can you polish your mysterious mirror And leave no blemish? Can you love the people and govern the state Without resorting to action?	What Can Be Done? Who by unending discipline of the senses embraces unity cannot be disintegrated. By concentrating his vitality and inducing tenderness he can become like a little child. By purifying, by cleansing and profound intuition he can be free from faults. Who loves the people when administering the country will	Unite physically and mentally to embrace One. Can one be not separated from it? Channel energy toward tenderness. Can one emulate the infant? Cleanse the deep mirror within. Can one be without blemishes? Love the populace in governance. Can one
leave the realm of Non-being and let these actions take place by themselves? Can the clear illumination radiate to all directions without your having knowledge of it? Cultivate it, and nourish it, Produce it, but do not possess it, Labor on it, but do not depend on it, Lead it, but do not manage it. This is called the mystic attainment.	governing the state, Can you practice nonaction? In opening and closing the heavenly gate, Can you play the feminine? In keeping clear-sighted and all-perceptive, Can you refrain from using craft? Generate them; Rear them. Generate without possessing; Lead without dominating - This is called deep and remote virtue.	and shut Are you capable of keeping to the role of the female? When your discernment penetrates the four quarters Are you capable of not knowing anything? It gives them life and rears them. It gives them life yet claims no possession; It benefits them yet exacts no gratitude; It is the steward yet exercises no authority.	practise nonassertion. Opening and closing the gates of heaven, he will be like a mother-bird; bright, and white, and penetrating the four quarters, he will be unsophisticated. He quickens them and feeds them. He quickens but owns not. He acts but claims not. He excels but rules not. This is called profound virtue.	practice laissez-faire? Open and close the cosmic portal. Can one assume the feminine role? Discern and deliberate. Can one be ignorant? Cultivate, rear. Cultivate, but possess not; Provide, but claim not; Nurture, but dominate not. This is the Profoundest virtue.

Thirty spokes are joined at the hub. From their non-being arises the function of the wheel. Lumps of clay are shaped into a vessel. From their non-being arises the function of the vessel. Doors and	Thirty spokes share a hub; In its nothingness Rests the carriage's usefulness. One burns clay to make a pot; In its nonbeing Rests the	Thirty spokes share one hub. Adapt the nothing therein to the purpose in hand, and you will have the use of the cart. Knead clay in order to make a vessel. Adapt the nothing therein to the purpose in hand, and you will have the use of the vessel.	The Function of the Non-Existent Thirty spokes unite in one nave and on that which is non-existent [on the hole in the nave] depends the wheel's utility. Clay is moulded into a vessel and on that which is non-existent [on its hollowness] depends the vessel's utility.	Thirty spokes share one hub. The hollow in the hub expresses the carriage's usefulness. With clay, a vessel is molded. The hollow within expresses the
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windows are constructed together to make a chamber. From their non-being arises the function of the chamber. Therefore, as individual beings, these things are useful materials. Constructed together in their non-being, they give rise to function.	clay pot's usefulness. One cuts out doors and windows; In its nonbeing Rests the room's usefulness. Therefore, being provides the advantage; Nonbeing provides the usefulness.	Cut out doors and windows in order to make a room. Adapt the nothing therein to the purpose in hand, and you will have the use of the room. Thus what we gain is Something, yet it is by virtue of Nothing that this can be put to use.	By cutting out doors and windows we build a house and on that which is non-existent [on the empty space within] depends the house's utility. Therefore, existence renders actual but non-existence renders useful.	vessel's usefulness. With doors and windows, a room is formed. The hollow within expresses the room's usefulness. Thus, visible provides the facility; hollow expresses its usefulness.
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Numerous colors make man sightless. Numerous sounds make man unable to hear. Numerous tastes make man tasteless. Racing and pursuing game make man's heart violent. Valuing rare things makes	The five colors make people's eyes blind; Gallop and hunting make people's heart go wild; Goods hard to come by make people's acts injurious. The five flavors make people's	The five colors make man's eyes blind; The five notes make his ears deaf; The five tastes injure his palate; Riding and hunting make his mind go wild with excitement;	Abstaining From Desire "The five colors [combined] the human eye will blind; The five notes [in one sound] the human ear confound; The five tastes [when they blend] the human mouth offend." "Racing	Five colors blind the eye; Five tones deafen the ear; Five flavors dull the palate. Prancing and hunting render one restless; Rare goods
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man worry about their safety. Therefore, the wise concentrates on the belly and not on the temptations of the senses. Thus, he abides in the one and foregoes the other.	mouth numb; The five notes make people's ears deaf. Hence, when the sage man ruled, He supported the stomach, but not the eye. Therefore, he abandoned that and chose this.	Goods hard to come by Serve to hinder his progress. Hence the sage is For the belly Not for the eye. Therefore he discards the one and takes the other.	and hunting will human hearts turn mad, Treasures high-prized make human conduct bad." Therefore The holy man attends to the inner and not to the outer. He abandons the latter and chooses the former.	render one senseless. Thus, a sage aims at the stomach and not at the eye, discarding the latter in favor of the former.
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Honor and dishonor both move us Because we are troubled by having a self. Why do we say that honor and dishonor move us? Because honor lifts us upward And dishonor lowers us downward, Thus, when we are honored we are moved. When we are dishonored we are also moved. That is why honor and dishonor are both said to move us.	"People cherish humiliations like surprises; They treasure great calamities like their lives." What is meant by "People cherish humiliations like surprises"? Humiliations are degrading, Yet they receive one like a surprise; Lose one like a surprise. This is what is meant by "People cherish humiliations like surprises." What is meant by "They treasure great calamities like their lives"?	Favor and disgrace are things that startle; High rank is, like one's body, a source of great trouble. What is meant by saying favor and disgrace are things that startle? Favor when it is bestowed on a subject serves to startle as much as when it is withdrawn. This is what is meant by saying that favor and disgrace are things that startle. What is meant by saying that high	Loathing Shame "Favor bodes disgrace; it is like trembling. Rank bodes great heartache. It is like the body." What means "Favor bodes disgrace; it is like trembling?" Favor humiliates. Its acquisition causes trembling, its loss causes trembling.	Receiving favor and receiving disgrace are both causes for concern, more so than being visited by a catastrophic disease. Why are favors and disgraces causes for concern? Favor is beneath one. Receiving it is a cause for concern; losing it is a cause for concern. Why [favors and disgraces] are more a cause for concern than being visited by a catastrophic disease?
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we say that the great trouble is having a self? Because we have great trouble simply because we have a self. If we are selfless, then where is the trouble? If we identify our self with the world, Then within our self there is the world. If we love the world as we love our self, Then within our self there is only the world.	why I have great calamities Is because I have my life; If I did not have my life, What calamities would I have? Therefore, if you treasure governing your life More than governing the empire, You deserve to be entrusted with the empire; If you grudge using your life To govern the empire, You deserve to be charged with the empire.	rank is, like one's body, a source of great trouble? The reason I have great trouble is that I have a body. When I no longer have a body, what trouble have I? Hence he who values his body more than dominion over the empire can be entrusted with the empire. He who loves his body more than dominion over the empire can be given the custody of the empire.	This is meant by "Favor bodes disgrace; it is like trembling." What means "Rank bodes great heartache, it is like the body?" I suffer great heartache because I have a body. When I have no body, what heartache remains? Therefore who administers the empire as he takes care of his body can be entrusted with the empire.	I have a catastrophic disease, it is inflicted upon my body. When I am beyond my body, how can I be visited by diseases? Thus, when one values one's body for the good of the world, one may be consigned with the world's care. When one treasures one's body for the good of the world, one may be vested with the world's care.
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Gaze at it; there is nothing to see. It is called the formless. Heed it; there is nothing to hear. It is called the soundless. Grasp it; there is nothing to hold on to. It is called the immaterial. We cannot inquire into these three, Hence, they interfuse into one. Above, it is not light. Below, it is not dark. Invisible, it cannot be called by any	Looking at it, you do not see it - This is called "invisible"; Listening to it, you do not hear it - This is called "inaudible"; Trying to touch it, you do not feel it - This is called "intangible." These three, which defy thorough inquiry, Long ago merged into One. One is something Whose past is not remote, Whose future, not transient. Continuous	What cannot be seen is called evanescent; What cannot be heard is called rarefied; What cannot be touched is called minute. These three cannot be fathomed And so they are confused and looked upon as one. Its upper part is not dazzling; Its lower part is not obscure. Dimly visible, it cannot be named And returns to that which is without substance.	Praising the Mysterious We look at Reason and do not see it; its name is Colorless. We listen to Reason and do not hear it; its name is Soundless. We grope for Reason and do not grasp it; its name is Bodiless. These three things cannot further be analyzed. Thus they are combined and conceived as a unity which on its surface is not clear and in its depth not obscure. Forever	Looking at it, it cannot be seen - label it invisible, Listening to it, it cannot be heard - label it inaudible, Holding onto it, it cannot be held - label it intangible. All three are beyond comprehension; they are One. Looking up, it is dim. Looking down, it is dark. It lacks clarity, it defies a
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name. It returns again to nothingness. Thus, we call it the form of the formless The image of the imageless. It is the evasive. Approach it; you cannot see its face. Go after it; you cannot see its back. Adhere to the Tao of the remote past, And apply it to the present. This will enable you to understand the primordial beginning.	and unending, It is unnameable, And again reverts to nothingness. This may be called the formless form, The immaterial image. This is called faint and dim: Following it, you do not see its tail; Meeting it, you do not see its head. Hold on to the present Tao To govern the present realm, Whereby you know its primeval origin. This is called the Tao's thread-head.	has no shape, The image that is without substance. This is called indistinct and shadowy. Go up to it and you will not see its head; Follow behind it and you will not see its rear. Hold fast to the way of antiquity In order to keep in control the realm of today. The ability to know the beginning of antiquity Is called the thread running through the way.	and aye Reason remains unnamable, and again and again it returns home to non-existence. This is called the form of the formless, the image of the imageless. This is called the transcendently abstruse. In front its beginning is not seen. In the rear its end is not seen. By holding fast to the Reason of the ancients, the present is mastered and the origin of the past understood. This is called Reason's clue.	name; it returns to Null. This is formless form, this is imageless image. This is elusiveness. Confronting it, one cannot see its head; Following it, one cannot see its tail. Seize Direction of the past - this is to manage the Ull of the present. Know it from the beginning - this is to understand the Direction's rhythm.
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In ancient times the best man of Tao was refined and deeply enlightened. His depth can hardly be measured. Because his depth can hardly be measured, I will try to draw a picture of him. Prudent, as if he were wading in a cold stream in the winter; Calm, as if he did not want to disturb his neighbors; Respectful, as if he were a guest; Fluid, as if he were ice melting;	In antiquity, he who excelled in implementing the Tao Was minutely discerning and subtly perceptive, Profound beyond recognition. As he was beyond recognition, I reluctantly depict him thus: "Undecided, as if in winter, wading through water; Hesitant, as if fearing the four neighbors; Awe-inspiring, like a guest;	Of old he who was well versed in the way Was minutely subtle, mysteriously comprehending, And too profound to be known. It is because he could not be known That he can only be given a makeshift description: Tentative, as if fording a river in winter, Hesitant, as if in fear of his neighbors; Formal like a guest;	The Revealers of Virtue Those of yore who have succeeded in becoming masters are subtle, spiritual, profound, and penetrating. On account of their profundity they can not be understood. Because they can not be understood, therefore I endeavor to make them intelligible.	One who understood Direction in olden days knew the tiniest, appreciated the profoundest, and was deep beyond [our] comprehension. Since such a person is beyond [our] comprehension, he/she can only be described superficially: as deliberate as approaching a deep channel in the winter, as alert as keeping watch over bordering states, as diplomatic as an envoy in presenting, as graceful as ice in slow melting,
Solid, as if he were an uncarved block; Vacant, as if he were a valley; Lacking clear discriminations, as if he were impure; Who is able to gradually reach purity from impurity through quiescence? Who is able to gradually grow lively from motion through motionlessness? One who abides in Tao never desires to reach an extreme. Because he never desires to reach an extreme,	Simple, like the unhewn log; Turbid, like muddy water; Expansive, like a valley. In muddy water, he stilled it And gradually made it limpid; In comfort, he stirred it And gradually made it vital." Those who treasure this Tao Do not wish to be full,	ice; Thick like the uncarved block; Vacant like a valley; Murky like muddy water. Who can be muddy and yet, settling, slowly become limpid? Who can be at rest and yet, stirring, slowly come to life? He who holds fast to this way Desires not to be full. It is because he is not full That he can be worn and yet newly made.	How elusive! They resemble ice when melting. How simple! They resemble rough wood. How empty! They resemble the valley. How obscure! They resemble troubled waters. Who by quieting can gradually render muddy waters clear? Who by stirring can gradually quicken the still? He who cherishes this Reason is not anxious to be filled. Since he is not filled, therefore he may grow old; without renewal he is complete.	block of uncarved wood, as calm as a valley's mood, as accommodating as muddy water, as expansive as the sea, as unending as the wind. Who can calm the muddy to let it distill? Who can motivate the serene to let it instill? One who understands Direction never fills to the brim. Not filled to the brim, one is at ready to remove the old and substitute it with new.

Contemplate the ultimate void. Remain truly in quiescence. All things are together in action, But I look into their non-action. Things are unceasingly moving and restless, Yet each one is proceeding back to the origin. Proceeding back to the origin is quiescence. To be in quiescence is to return to the destiny of being. The destiny of being is reality.	Attain emptiness to the utmost; Adhere to stillness indefatigably. The ten thousand things rise everywhere; I thereby observe their revolution. While things grow exuberantly, Each will again revert to its root, Which means stillness; Stillness means reverting to life; Reverting to life is the constant. Knowing	I do my utmost to attain emptiness; I hold firmly to stillness. The myriad creatures all rise together And I watch their return. The teaming creatures All return to their separate roots. Returning to one's roots is known as stillness. This is what is meant by returning to one's destiny. Returning to one's destiny is known as the constant. Knowledge	Returning to the Root By attaining the height of abstraction we gain fullness of rest. All the ten thousand things arise, and I see them return. Now they bloom in bloom but each one homeward returneth to its root. Returning to the root means rest. It signifies the return according to destiny.	Aim at the supreme hollow, reach for the utmost serenity. Matters bloom in myriad diversity. I watch for periodicity. Matters blossom and return to their roots. Returning to roots leads to serenity. Serenity leads to regeneration. Regeneration leads to normalcy. Knowing normalcy
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is to be enlightened. Not to understand it, and to act wrongly, leads to disaster. Reality is all-embracing. To be all-embracing is to be selfless. To be selfless is to be all-pervading. To be all-pervading is to be transcendent. To be transcendent is to attain Tao. To attain Tao is to be everlasting. Even when the body dies, it is not the end.	the constant is clear-sighted. Not knowing the constant is blind; Acting blindly is disastrous. Knowing the constant leads to all-embracingness; All-embracingness leads to impartiality; Impartiality leads to kingliness; Kingliness leads to heaven; Heaven leads to the Tao; The Tao leads to permanence; A lifetime without peril.	of the constant is known as discernment. Woe to him who wilfully innovates While ignorant of the constant, But should one act from knowledge of the constant One's action will lead to impartiality, Impartiality to kingliness, Kingliness to heaven, Heaven to the way, The way to perpetuity, And to the end of one's days one will meet with no danger.	Return according to destiny means the eternal. Knowing the eternal means enlightenment. Not knowing the eternal causes passions to rise; and that is evil. Knowing the eternal renders comprehensive. Comprehensiveness renders broad. Breadth renders royal. Royalty renders heavenly. Heaven renders Reason-like. Reason renders lasting. Thus the decay of the body implies no danger.	leads to comprehension. Not knowing normalcy, indiscretion leads to misfortune. Knowing normalcy is all-accommodating; All-accommodating is non-discriminating. Non-discriminating is all-encompassing. All-encompassing is the cosmos. Cosmos is Direction. Direction is long lasting.
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The best leader is one whom no one knows.

The next best is one who is intimate with the people and is flattered by them.

The next is one who is feared by the people.

The next is one who is held

The supreme sovereign - the people barely knew he was there;

The next - they loved and praised him;

The next - they feared him;

The lowest - they despised

The best of all rulers is but a shadowy presence to his subjects.

Next comes the ruler they love and praise;

Next comes one they fear;

Next comes one with whom they take liberties.

When

Simplicity In Habits

Of great rulers the subjects do not notice the existence. To lesser ones people are attached; they praise them. Still lesser ones people fear, and the meanest ones people despise.

For it

At the highest level, one is unseen.

At the next level, one is liked and praised.

At the next level, one is feared.

At the next level, one

in contempt by the people.

Therefore, when one's sincerity is not sufficient, one does not have the confidence of the people.

Be cautious! and spare words.

Then when work is done and things are accomplished,

People will say that things happened by themselves.

him.

Only when his trust became deficient

Was there distrust.

Hesitant, he grudged his words;

Merits scored, affairs accomplished,

The hundred family names said: "That's the way things are with us."

there is not enough faith, there is lack of good faith.

Hesitant, he does not utter words lightly.

When his task is accomplished and his work done

The people all say, 'It happened to us naturally.'

is said:

"If your faith be insufficient, verily, you will receive no faith."

How reluctantly they [the great rulers] considered their words! Merit they accomplished; deeds they performed; and the hundred families thought: "We are independent."

is ridiculed.

One lacking in trustworthiness loses the [populace's] trust.

Carefree, one values one's words.

With work accomplished and business done, the gentry say: "We do this naturally."

As soon as the great Tao is cast aside, There prevails the teaching of benevolence and righteousness. As soon as intellection and prudence are esteemed, There is produced the great falsehood. As soon as the	Therefore, only when the great Tao was abandoned Was there humanity and righteousness; Only when craft emerged Was there great deception; Only when	When the great way falls into disuse There are benevolence and rectitude; When cleverness emerges There is great hypocrisy;	The Palliation of Vulgarly When the great Reason is obliterated, we have benevolence and justice. Prudence and circumspection appear, and we have much hypocrisy. When family relations no longer harmonize, we have filial piety and paternal devotion.	When Grand Direction is not in evidence, nobleness and righteousness come to the fore. When cleverness and glibness are in view, grand pretenses come to the
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members of a family are no longer at peace, There is a demand for filial piety and love. As soon as a nation is in confusion and rebellion, There is a claim for loyal officers.	the six blood relations became discordant Was there filial piety and parental love; Only when state and fief became chaotic Were there upright officials.	When the six relations are at variance There are filial children; When the state is benighted There are loyal ministers.	When the country and the clans decay through disorder, we have loyalty and allegiance.	fore. When family relations are in disharmony, filiality and parental love come to the fore. When a state is in disarray, loyal ministers come to the fore.
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Let the people be free from discernment and relinquish intellection, Then they will be many times better off. Stop the teaching of benevolence and get rid of the claim of justice, Then the people will love each other once more. Cease the teaching of cleverness and give up profit, Then there will	Eliminate sageness, abandon craft, And the people shall benefit a hundredfold; Eliminate humanity, abandon righteousness, And the people shall revert to filial piety and parental love; Eliminate adroitness, abandon profit, And robbers and thieves there shall	Exterminate learning and there will no longer be worries. Exterminate the sage, discard the wise, And the people will benefit a hundredfold; Exterminate benevolence, discard rectitude, And the people will again be filial; Exterminate ingenuity, discard profit, And there will be no	Returning to Simplicity Abandon your saintliness; put away your prudence; and the people will gain a hundredfold! Abandon your benevolence; put away your justice; and the people will return to filial piety and paternal devotion. Abandon smartness; give up greed;	Renounce saintliness, shun cleverness - let the populace be better off by a hundredfold. Renounce nobleness, shun righteousness - let the populace return to filiality and parental love. Renounce scheming,
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be no more stealing and fraud. Discernment and intellection, benevolence and justice, cleverness and profit are nothing but outward refinements. Hence we must seek something other than these. Reveal simplicity, Hold to one's original nature, Rid one's self of selfishness, Cast away covetousness,	be none. These three remarks are considered rhetorically inadequate, Therefore, let us put them where they belong: "Display the undyed silk and embrace the unhewn log; Diminish selfishness and reduce lusts; Eliminate learning and dispense with anxiety."	more thieves and bandits. These three, being false adornments, are not enough And the people must have something to which they can attach themselves: Exhibit the unadorned and embrace the uncarved block, Have little thought of self and as few desires as possible.	and thieves and robbers will no longer exist. These are three things for which culture is insufficient. Therefore it is said: "Hold fast to that which will endure, Show thyself simple, preserve thee pure, And lessen self with desires fewer."	shun profiteering - let robbers and thieves vanish. The three are inadequate formulation. Better channel [the populace] to Direction. Welcome purity, embrace simplicity; Minimize self-interest, reduce desire. Renounce learning, eliminate apprehension.
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What is the difference between the respectful "wei" and the disrespectful "o"? What is the difference between good and bad? Where others are afraid, must I be afraid, too? How extremely ridiculous this is! The people are rejoicing as if they are enjoying a sacrificial feast, Or walking up a terrace in the blossoming spring. How quiescent I am, alone unstirred, like a baby before he knows how to make pleasant expressions. How aimlessly I wander, with no home to turn to. People all have many ambitions	Between "Yes, sir" and "Of course, not!" - How much difference is there? Between good and evil - What difference it is! He whom the people fear Cannot but fear the people also. Faintly, it seems boundless! The multitude is jubilant, As if feasting on the Grand Pen, Or, in springtime, ascending a tower; I am disinterested, showing no sign whatever, Like an infant who cannot smile yet; Fatigued, as if	Between yea and nay How much difference is there? Between good and evil How great is the distance? What others fear One must also fear. The multitude are joyous As if partaking of the offering Or going up to a terrace in spring. I alone am inactive and reveal no signs, And wax without having reached the limit. Like a baby that has not yet learned to smile, Listless as though with no home to go back	Different from the Vulgar Abandon learnedness, and you have no vexation. The "yes" compared with the "yea," how little do they differ! But the good compared with the bad, how much do they differ! If what the people dread cannot be made dreadless, there will be desolation, alas! and verily, there will be no end of it. The multitudes of men are happy, so happy, as though celebrating a great feast. They are as though in springtime ascending a tower. I alone remain quiet, alas! like one that has not yet received an omen. I am like unto a babe that does not yet smile. Forlorn am I, O so forlorn!	Between obsequiousness and authoritativeness - what is the difference? Between beauty and ugliness - is there a difference? What others fear, do not be unfearful. Uncultivated, it is because it is unfinished. Other people are happily gathered, as if readying to partake in an exquisite banquet, to view a spring parade. I stand alone, quietly, inconspicuously. Innocently, as if an infant not knowing how
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and desires. I, alone, seem to have left all of them. How ignorant I am! My mind must be that of a fool. People are glorious and shining. I, alone, am dark and dull. People are clever and inquisitive. I, alone, am obscure and blunt. How tranquil I am, like the placid sea. How loftily drifting, as if I am bound nowhere. People all have their motives. I, alone, am good for nothing and uncouth. I am not like the others.	having nowhere to return. The multitude all has enough and to spare; I, alone, am destitute. Mine is a fool's mind indeed, how stupid! The vulgar are clear-sighted; I alone am benighted. The vulgar are discerning; I alone am muddle-headed. Dimly, like an ocean! Faintly, as if endless! The multitude is all enterprising; I alone am slow and clumsy. I wish to be uniquely different from others, And cherish my nursing mother.	to. The multitude all have more than enough. I alone seem to be in want. My mind is that of a fool - how blank! Vulgar people are clear. I alone am drowsy. Vulgar people are alert. I alone am muddled. Calm like the sea; Like a high wind that never ceases. The multitude all have a purpose. I alone am foolish and uncouth. I alone am different from others And value being fed by the mother.	It appears that I have no place whither I may return home. The multitude of men all have plenty and I alone appear empty. Alas! I am a man whose heart is foolish. Ignorant am I, O, so ignorant! Common people are bright, so bright, I alone am dull. Common people are smart, so smart, I alone am confused, so confused. Desolate am I, alas! like the sea. Adrift, alas! like one who has no place where to stay. The multitude of men all possess usefulness. I alone am awkward and a rustic too. I alone differ from others, but I prize seeking sustenance from our mother.	to smile; Aimlessly, as if a wanderer not knowing where to go. Other people have much to spare; I, alone, am bare. Perhaps my foolish heart. Common people glow; I, alone, am in the dark. Common people are alert; I, alone, am stark. Other people are skillful; I, alone, am clumsy and bashful. I am different from others; I treasure being embraced by Mother.
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That which is inherent in the great attainment (void) is the echo of Tao. That which is Tao is indistinct and ineffable. Ineffable and indistinct, yet therein are forms. Indistinct and ineffable, yet therein are objects. Unfathomable and invisible, yet therein are essences. The essence	The manifestations of grand virtue Follow only the Tao. The Tao is something Faint and dim: Dim and faint, Therein lies an image; Faint and dim, Therein lies substance. Deep and remote, Therein lies quintessence. Its quintessence is	In his every movement a man of great virtue Follows the way and the way only. As a thing the way is Shadowy and indistinct. Indistinct and shadowy, Yet within it is an image; Shadowy and indistinct, Yet within it is a substance. Dim and dark, Yet within it is an essence.	Emptying the Heart "Vast virtue's form Follows Reason's norm. "And Reason's nature Is vague and eluding. "How eluding and vague All types including! How vague and eluding, All beings including! How deep and how obscure. It harbors the spirit pure, Whose truth	The Grand Virtue's complexion resembles that of Direction. Direction, as a matter substantive, is sometimes indistinct and other times elusive. Elusive and indistinct, there is image within; Indistinct and elusive, there is matter within. Minuscule and mysterious, there are particles within;
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is indeed genuine, therein is the vivid reality. From ancient times until the present, the name of Tao has never ceased to exist. Through it we see the beginning of all things. How do we understand the beginning of all things? It is through this.	most genuine, Therein lies truthfulness. From the present to antiquity, Its name has never vanished, Whereby I trace back to The father of the multitude. How do I know What the father of the multitude was like? From this.	essence is quite genuine And within it is something that can be tested. From the present back to antiquity, Its name never deserted it. It serves as a means for inspecting the fathers of the multitude. How do I know that the fathers of the multitude are like that? By means of this.	is ever sure, Whose faith abides for aye From of yore until to-day. "Its name is never vanishing, It heeds the good of everything." Through what do I know that "it heeds the good of everything"? In this way, verily: Through IT.	These particles are real; there is reality within. From the present back to the past, its name is never unacknowledged; it is the foundation of all matters. How do I know that it is the foundation of all matters? Through Direction.
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To bend is to maintain integrity. To deviate is to be direct. To be concave is to be convex. To be exhausted is to be rejuvenated. To be wanting is to be endowed. To have much is to be deprived. Therefore, the wise identifies opposites as one, And sets an example for the world. He remains in concealment and spontaneously is unconcealed. He does not assert	"Incomplete shall be complete; Bent shall be straight; Hollow shall be full; Worn shall be new; Little shall gain; Much shall delude." Hence, the sage man Took hold of One to serve As shepherd over all under heaven: He did not look at himself, Therefore, illustrious; He did not	Bowed down then preserved; Bent then straight; Hollow then full; Worn then new; A little then benefited; A lot then perplexed. Therefore the sage embraces the One and is a model for the empire. He does not show himself, and so is conspicuous; He does not consider himself right, and so is illustrious; He does not	Humility's Increase "The crooked shall be straight, Crushed ones recuperate, The empty find their fill. The worn with strength shall thrill; Who little have receive, And who have much will grieve." Therefore The holy man embraces unity and becomes for all the world a model. Not self-displaying he is enlightened;	Accommodate and be whole, bend and be straight; Keep low and be fulfilled, replace old and be new; Seek little and gain, seek plenty and be bewildered. Thus, the sage embraces One to set an example for the people of the world. Not self-touting,
himself, therefore he is eminent. He does not claim credit, therefore he receives credit. He is not vain, therefore he is the best. Because he does not oppose anyone in the world, no one can oppose him. Thus, the ancient saying "to bend is to maintain integrity" is the word of truth. Indeed, integrity is attributed to this. Through no words, It takes place by itself.	parade himself, Therefore, clear-sighted; He did not brag about himself, Therefore, meritorious; He was not conceited, Therefore, long-enduring. It is precisely because he did not contend That none could with him contend. The ancient saying: "Incomplete shall be complete" - Is it mere words? Truly, it shall end up complete.	brag, and so has merit; He does not boast, and so endures. It is because he does not contend that no one in the empire is in a position to contend with him. The way the ancients had it, 'Bowed down then preserved', is no empty saying. Truly it enables one to be preserved to the end.	he is distinguished; Not self-asserting he acquires merit; Not self-seeking he gaineth life. Since he does not quarrel, therefore no one in the world can quarrel with him. The saying of the ancients: "The crooked shall be straight," is it in any way vainly spoken? Verily, they will be straightened and return home.	one shines; Not self-justifying, one reassures; Not self-aggrandizing, one accomplishes; Not self-serving, one endures. When one is not in competition, people in the world cannot engage him/her in competition. Is the old saying "Accommodate and be whole" but empty words? It can be realized fully.

Nature rarely expresses itself in words. When a hurricane occurs, it does not last all morning. Neither does a heavy shower last the whole day. These are actions of heaven and earth. Thus, even heaven and earth cannot maintain their actions for long. How can man? Therefore, the learner of Tao identifies with Tao.	Speechlessness conforms to the way things are. A turbulent wind does not last a whole morning; A torrential rain does not last a whole day. Who does these? Heaven and earth. Even heaven and earth cannot last long, How can man? Therefore, he who pursues the	To use words but rarely Is to be natural. Hence a gusty wind cannot last all morning, and a sudden downpour cannot last all day. Who is it that produces these? Heaven and earth. If even heaven and earth cannot go on forever, much less can man. That is why one follows the way. A man of the way conforms	Emptiness and Non-Existence To be taciturn is the natural way. A hurricane: does not outlast the morning. A cloudburst does not outlast the day. Who causes these events but heaven and earth? If even heaven and earth cannot be unremitting, will not man be much less so? Those who pursue their business in Reason, men of Reason, associate in Reason.	To be reticent is natural. Thus, a whirlwind does not last all morning, a downpour does not last all day. Why is this so? Because this is the universe. Even the universe cannot sustain; can humans? Thus, one who follows Direction manages with Direction, One who follows virtue manages with virtue,
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When one achieves it, one identifies with one's achievement. When one loses it, one identifies with one's losing. When man identifies with achievement, achievement also willingly identifies with man. When man identifies with losing, losing willingly identifies with man. If one does not believe enough in this identity, then it will not take place.	Tao Identifies with the Tao; He who pursues virtue identifies with virtue; He who pursues loss identifies with loss. He who identifies with virtue - The Tao, too, shall requite him with favor; He who identifies with loss - The Tao, too, shall requite him with loss.	to the way; A man of virtue conforms to virtue; A man of loss conforms to loss. He who conforms to the way is gladly accepted by the way; He who conforms to virtue is gladly accepted by virtue; He who conforms to loss is gladly accepted by loss. When there is not enough faith, there is lack of good faith.	Those who pursue their business in virtue associate in virtue. Those who pursue their business in ill luck associate in ill luck. When men associate in Reason, Reason makes them glad to find companions. When men associate in virtue, virtue makes them glad to find companions. When men associate in ill luck, ill luck makes them glad to find companions. "If your faith is insufficient, verily shall ye receive no faith."	follow Direction nor virtue manages with neither Direction nor virtue. One who manages with Direction is welcome by those with Direction, One who manages with virtue is welcome by those with virtue, One who manages with neither Direction nor virtue is welcome by those without Direction or virtue. One lacking in trustworthiness loses [the populace's] trust.
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To lift the heel is not to stand. To take long strides is not to walk. To show off is not to shine. To insist that one is right is not to be distinct. To claim credit is to have	He who boasts cannot stand; He who looks at himself is not illustrious; He who parades himself is not clear-sighted; He who brags about himself has no merit; He who	He who tiptoes cannot stand; he who strides cannot walk. He who shows himself is not conspicuous; He who considers himself right is not illustrious; He who brags will have no merit; He who boasts	Trouble From Indulgence One on tiptoe is not steady; One astride makes no advance. Self-displayers are not enlightened, Self-asserters lack distinction, Self-approvers have no merit, And self-seekers stunt their lives. Before Reason	One who tiptoes to stand taller does not stand firm; One who strides to walk faster does not walk long; One who self-touts does not shine; One who self-justifies does not reassure; One who
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no credit. To be proud of oneself is not to be the best. From the point of view of Tao, all of these are extras which things themselves do not like. Therefore, the man of Tao does not abide with them.	is conceited does not last long. These, according to the Tao, are Leftover food and improper deeds Which people all loathe. Therefore, he who possesses the Tao Does not accumulate.	will not endure. From the point of view of the way these are 'excessive food and useless excrescences'. As there are Things that detest them, he who has the way does not abide in them.	this is like surfeit of food; it is like a wen on the body with which people are apt to be disgusted. Therefore the man of reason will not indulge in it.	self-aggrandizes does not accomplish; One who self-serves does not endure. They, in relation to Direction, are the equivalent of leftover food and excess fat. They are unattractive; they are not held by those with Direction.
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There was a thing, a "gathering" chaos, Which existed prior to heaven and earth. Silent! Empty! Existing by itself, unchanging, Pervading everywhere, inexhaustible, It might be called the mother of the world. Its name is unknown; I simply call it Tao. If I were to exert myself to define it, I might call it great.	There was something That into an indistinguishable mass had wrought itself, Born before heaven and earth. Desolate and formless, It stood alone, unchanging, And may be regarded as The mother of heaven and earth. Not knowing its name, I gave it the alias "Tao," And reluctantly named it "vast." Vast and	There is a thing confusedly formed, Born before heaven and earth. Silent and void It stands alone and does not change, Goes round and does not weary. It is capable of being the mother of the world. I know not its name So I style it 'the way'. I give it the makeshift name of 'the great'. Being great, it is further described as receding, Receding, it	Imaging the Mysterious There is a Being wondrous and complete. Before heaven and earth, it was. How calm it is! How spiritual! Alone it standeth, and it changeth not; around it moveth, and it suffereth not; yet therefore can it be the world's mother. Its name I know not, but its nature I call Reason. Constrained to give a name, I call it the great.	A matter is molded; it comes into being before the universe, noiseless and formless. It stands by itself, unwaveringly; it is in motion, unendingly. It may be the Mother to the universe. I do not know its name. Tentatively, [I] label it Direction and call it Grand. Grand is unending motion; unending motion
to the limitless means reaching the extreme distance. Reaching the extreme distance means returning to "nearness." Thus, Tao is great, Heaven is great, earth is great, and man is great, too. In the universe we have four greatnesses, and man is but one. Man is in accordance with earth. Earth is in accordance with heaven. Heaven is in accordance with Tao.	moving; Moving and far-reaching; Far-reaching and reverting. The Tao is vast; Heaven is vast; Earth is vast; The king is also vast. In the empire, there are four vasts, And the king constitutes one. Man imitates earth; Earth imitates heaven; Heaven imitates the Tao; The Tao imitates the way things are.	is described as far away, Being far away, it is described as turning back. Hence the way is great; Heaven is great; Earth is great; The king is also great. Within the realm there are four things that are great, And the king counts as one. Man models himself on earth, Earth on heaven, Heaven on the way,	The great I call the departing, and the departing I call the beyond. The beyond I call home. The saying goes: "Reason is great, heaven is great, earth is great, and royalty also is great.[There are four things in the world that are great, and royalty is one of them.] Man's standard is the earth. The earth's standard is heaven. Heaven's standard is Reason. Reason's standard is intrinsic.	is far-reaching; Far-reaching is periodicity. Thus, Direction is grand, the cosmos is grand, the earth is grand, the human is also grand. There are four Grands in the universe, and the human is one of them. The human follows the earth, The earth follows the cosmos, The cosmos follows Direction,

The weighty is the origin of the weightless. Stillness is the fountain of restlessness. Therefore, the ruler journeys from morning until night and never separates himself from his heavy supply cart. Although he is in a glorious	Heaviness is the root of lightness; Stillness is the sovereign of restlessness. Hence, the gentleman journeyed all day Without leaving his luggage vans. Though having imperial guards, In leisure,	The heavy is the root of the light; The still is the lord of the restless. Therefore the gentleman when travelling all day Never lets the heavily laden carts out of his sight. It is only when he is safely behind walls and	The Virtue of Gravity The heavy is of the light the root, and rest is motion's master. Therefore the holy man in his daily walk does not depart from gravity. Although he may have magnificent sights, he calmly sits with liberated mind.	Earnestness is the foundation of frivolity; serenity is in control of rashness. Thus, a gentleman, in the course of a day, does not depart from serenity and earnestness. He
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atmosphere, he remains quiescent and above it. How can a leader "with ten thousand chariots" take himself lightly before the world? To take himself lightly is to lose the origin. Restlessness means that the fountain is lost.	he was as clear as day. How could a ten-thousand-chariot king Conduct himself lightly over all under heaven? Light, he would lose his root; Restless, he would lose his sovereignty.	watch-towers That he rests peacefully and is above worries. How, then, should a ruler of ten thousand chariots Make light of his own person in the eyes of the empire? If light, then the root is lost; If restless, then the lord is lost.	But how is it when the master of the ten thousand chariots in his personal conduct is too light for the empire? If he is too light he will lose his vassals. If he is too passionate he will lose the throne.	refrains from extravagance [in public] and lives plainly at home. Why would the sovereign of a ten-thousand-carriage state govern the world with frivolity? Frivolity loses foundation; rashness loses control.
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The best action is free from marks [either good or evil].

The best words are free from stains [either good or bad].

The best calculator is free from calculation and measure.

The best closure has no bolts, yet it cannot be opened.

The best knot has no cord, yet it cannot be untied.

Thus, the wise knows how to rescue men; hence, no

A good traveler leaves neither ruts nor footprints;

A good speaker makes neither slips nor errors;

A good calculator uses neither wooden chips nor bamboo chips;

A good door-shutter has neither latch nor lock,

Yet, the door he shuts cannot be opened;

A good knot-tier has neither rope nor string,

Yet, the knot he ties cannot be untied.

Hence, the sage

m —

One who excels in travelling leaves no wheel tracks;

One who excels in speech makes no slips;

One who excels in reckoning uses no counting rods;

One who excels in shutting uses no bolts yet what he has shut cannot be opened.

One who excels in tying uses no cords yet what he has tied cannot be undone.

Therefore the sage always excels in saving people,

The Function of Skill

"Good travelers leave no trace nor track,

Good speakers, in logic show no lack,

Good counters need no counting rack.

"Good lockers bolting bars need not,

Yet none their locks can loose.

Good binders need no string nor knot,

Yet none unties their noose."

Therefore the holy man is always a good saviour of men, for there are no outcast people.

A good traveler leaves no trails;

A good speaker allows no slips;

A good planner needs no tallies;

A good carpenter needs no bolts in securing a door from opening;

A good packager needs no strings in preventing a knot from untying.

Thus,

the sage cares for everyone and abandons no one, cares

one is excluded.

He also knows how to rescue things; hence, nothing is excluded.

This is called penetration to illumination.

Therefore, the virtuous is the model for the unvirtuous.

The unvirtuous is the origin of the virtuous.

If one does not appreciate the virtuous or cherish the unvirtuous,

Although one is intelligent, one is not free from confusion.

Was constantly good at rescuing men

So that there were no cast-off men;

As for things,

There were no cast-off goods.

This is called surpassing insight.

Hence, good men are good men's teachers;

Evil men, good men's wealth.

He who neither values his teachers,

Nor cherishes his wealth,

Though crafty, is but a big fool.

and so abandons no one;

Always excels in saving things, and so abandons nothing.

This is called following one's discernment.

Hence the good man is the teacher the bad learns from;

And the bad man is the material the good works on.

Not to value the teacher

Nor to love the material

Though it seems clever, betrays great bewilderment.

He is always a good saviour of things, for there are no outcast things. This is called applied enlightenment.

Thus the good man does not respect multitudes of men. The bad man respects the people's wealth. Who does not esteem multitudes nor is charmed by their wealth, though his knowledge be greatly confused, he must be recognized as profoundly spiritual.

for everything and abandons nothing.

This is unrevealed wisdom.

Thus,

a good person serves as the teacher to a not-so-good person;

a not-so-good person serves as the mirror to a good person.

One who neither respects one's teacher nor cares for one's mirror, even if wise, will be bewildered.

This is the innermost intricacy.

To be aware of the positive, yet to abide in the negative is to be the abyss of the universe.

To be the abyss of the universe is to not deviate from real attainment and to remain like an innocent child.

To be aware of the white, yet to abide in the black is to be

Knowing his masculinity,
Adhering to his femininity,
He remained to all under heaven a brook.

Being to all under heaven a brook,

His constant virtue never departed.

His constant virtue never departed,

He again reverted to infancy.

Knowing his whiteness

Adhering to his blackness,
He remained to all under heaven a valley.

Being to all under heaven a valley,

His constant virtue was sufficient.

His constant virtue being sufficient,

He

Know the male

But keep to the role of the female

And be a ravine to the empire.

If you are a ravine to the empire,

Then the constant virtue will not desert you

And you will again return to being a babe.

Know the white

But keep to the role of the sullied

And be a model to the empire.

If you are a model to the empire,

Then the constant virtue will not be

Returning to Simplicity

"Who his manhood shows

And his womanhood knows

Becomes the empire's river.

Is he the empire's river,

He will from virtue never deviate,

And home he turneth to a child's estate.

"Who his brightness shows

And his blackness knows

Becomes the empire's model.

Is he the empire's model,

Of virtue ne'er shall he be destitute,

Know steeliness, but prefer tenderness.

Be the brook to the world.

The brook to the world is never disunited from virtue.

It aims to return to infancy.

Know limelight, but prefer shadow.

Be the standard to the world.

The standard to the world never deviates from virtue.

It aims to return to the Infinite.

the chasm of the universe.

To be the chasm of the universe is to have sufficient real attainment, and to remain in the state of original non-differentiation.

When original non-differentiation is differentiated, things are produced.

Yet when the wise makes use of original non-differentiation, he becomes the leader of the people.

Therefore, great governing is non-discriminating.

again reverted to the unhewn log.

[Knowing his whiteness,

Adhering to his blackness,

He remained to all under heaven a horizontal bar

Being to all under heaven a horizontal bar,

His constant virtue never changed.

His constant virtue never changed,

He again reverted to Infinity.]

When the unhewn log dispersed,

It became vessels;

When the sage man was employed,

He became chief of the officialdom.

A great tailor does no cutting.

wanting

And you will return to the infinite,

Know honour

But keep to the role of the disgraced

And be a valley to the empire.

If you are a valley to the empire,

Then the constant virtue will be sufficient

And you will return to being the uncarved block.

When the uncarved block shatters it becomes vessels.

The sage makes use of these and becomes the lord over the officials.

turneth to the absolute.

"Who knows his fame

And guards his shame

Becomes the empire's valley.

Is he the empire's valley,

For e'er his virtue will sufficient be,

And home he turneth to simplicity."

Simplicity, when scattered, becomes a vessel of usefulness. The holy man, by using it, becomes the chief leader; and truly, a great principle will never do harm.

Know fame, but prefer humility.

Be the valley to the world.

The valley to the world is filled with virtue.

It aims to return to simplicity.

Simplicity dissipates when [a block] is carved into a vessel.

A sage diminishes when [he/she] is used as a leader.

Thus, a great system is not cut up.

If one undertakes the task of governing the kingdom and engages in governing it,
I see that he cannot lead it anywhere.
A kingdom is a spiritual vessel and should not be manipulated.
Manipulating it leads to failure.
To grasp

He who wishes to win all under heaven,
And act upon them -
In my view, he cannot prevail.
All under heaven are sacred vessels
That cannot be acted upon.
He who acts upon them ruins them;
He who

Whoever takes the empire and wishes to do anything to it I see will have no respite.
The empire is a sacred vessel and nothing should be done to it.
Whoever does anything to it will ruin it;
whoever lays

Non-Assertion
When one desires to take in hand the empire and make it, I see him not succeed.
The empire is a divine vessel which cannot be made. One who makes it, mars it. One who takes it, loses it.

One who plans to govern the people in the world with coercion is, in my view, unlikely to succeed.
The people in the world are revered specimens,
They cannot be coerced; they cannot be dominated.
One who seeks to coerce is defeated;
One who seeks to dominate loses.
The

it is to miss it.
Because the natures of things vary, one acts, another copies;
One breathes lightly, another breathes heavily;
One is vigorous, one is meek;
One carries on, another fails.
Thus, the wise is not excessive, overindulgent, or extreme.

holds on to them loses them.
For people -
Some walk; some follow;
Some blow warm; some blow cold;
Some are strong; some weak;
Some safe; some in danger.
Hence, the sage man
Abandoned excessiveness;
Abandoned arrogance;
Abandoned extravagance.

hold of it will lose it.
Hence some things lead and some follow;
Some breathe gently and some breathe hard;
Some are strong and some are weak;
Some destroy and some are destroyed.
Therefore the sage avoids excess, extravagance, and arrogance.

And it is said of beings:
"Some are obsequious, others move boldly,
Some breathe warmly, others coldly,
Some are strong and others weak,
Some rise proudly, others sneak."
Therefore the holy man abandons excess, he abandons extravagance, he abandons indulgence.

sage practices laissez-faire.
Thus, the sage will not be defeated, the sage will not lose.
Among matters, some lead and others follow;
some breathe slowly and others fast;
some are robust and others slim;
some play safe and others blast.
Thus,
the sage discards extremes, discards extravagances, discards excesses.

Aiding in governing the kingdom through Tao means not depending on the superiority of arms. Depending on the superiority of arms creates consequences. Wherever there are armies, disorder occurs. After a great battle, there is a year of deprivation. Victory is merely the outcome of a contest. One should not dare to claim superiority of power. As victory is merely an outcome, one should not boast about it. As	Use the Tao to assist your sovereign lord; Do not use military power To flaunt your strength over all under heaven. Such things are apt to boomerang: Where an army has encamped, Brambles and thorns grow. A good commander stops Once his end is achieved, And does not thereby seek military superiority. His end achieved,	One who assists the ruler of men by means of the way does not intimidate the empire by a show of arms. This is something which is liable to rebound. Where troops have encamped There will brambles grow; In the wake of a mighty army Bad harvests follow without fail.	Be Chary of War He who with Reason assists the master of mankind will not with arms strengthen the empire. His methods invite requital. Where armies are quartered briars and thorns grow. Great wars unfailingly are followed by famines. A good man acts resolutely and then stops.	One guided by Direction does not use military power to subdue the people in the world. It boomerangs. Where armies visit, thorns grow. After a great war, famines follow. One who knows war stops after the objective is reached. He dares not flaunt power. Reach objective, but boast
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it is merely an outcome, one should not show off because of it. As it is merely an outcome, one should not be proud of it. As it is merely an outcome, one cannot help but have it. As it is merely an outcome, one should not claim superiority of power. Claiming to be strong leads to decay. This violates Tao. That which violates Tao will not last long.	he is not arrogant; His end achieved, he is not conceited; His end achieved, he does not brag; His end achieved, he accepts it reluctantly. This is called Achieving the end without seeking military superiority. Something ages while still in its prime Is contrary to the Tao; What is contrary to the Tao perishes early.	Bring it to a conclusion but do not brag; Bring it to a conclusion but do not be arrogant; Bring it to a conclusion but only when there is no choice; Bring it to a conclusion but do not intimidate. A creature in its prime doing harm to the old Is known as going against the way. That which goes against the way will come to an early end.	He ventures not to take by force. Be resolute but not boastful; resolute but not haughty; resolute but not arrogant; resolute because you cannot avoid it; resolute but not violent. Things thrive and then grow old. This is called un-Reason. Un-Reason soon ceases.	not; reach objective, but tout not; reach objective, but show arrogance not; Reaching objective is because there is no alternative; Reaching objective does not call for flaunting power. Matter withers after saturation. This is not in line with Direction. Not in line with Direction, early demise is the expectation.
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Arms are implements of ill omen which are abhorred by men.	Weapons are inauspicious instruments	It is because arms are instruments of ill omen and there are Things that detest them that the one who has the way does not abide by their use.	Quelling War	Weaponry are not instruments of the good;
Therefore, the man of Tao does not abide them.	Which people all loathe.	The gentleman gives precedence to the left when at home, but to the right when he goes to war.	Even victorious arms are unblest among tools, and people had better shun them.	they are disliked by everyone.
Arms are implements of ill omen.	Therefore, he who possesses the Tao	Arms are instruments of ill omen, not the instruments of the gentleman.	Therefore he who has Reason does not rely on them.	One with Direction does not harbor them.
One uses them only when one cannot avoid it.	Does not accumulate.	When one is compelled to use them, it is best to do so without relish.	The superior man when residing at home honors the left. When using arms, he honors the right.	A gentleman,
Even if one engages in	The gentleman ordinarily honors the left;	There is no glory in victory, and so to glorify it despite this is to	Arms are unblest among tools and not the superior man's tools.	at home, takes the left position;
	At war, he honors the right.			in war, the right position.
	Therefore, weapons are not the gentleman's instruments.			Weaponry are not instruments of the good;
	Weapons being inauspicious instruments,			they are not a gentleman's instruments.
	If you cannot but use them,			Use them only because there is no alternative;
	It is best to cover up their sharp blades;			use them with restraint.
	Do not relish them.			
	If you relish them,			
	It means you enjoy killing men.			

fighting, one should remain quiescent and indifferent.	who enjoys killing men	exult in the killing of men.	Only when it is unavoidable he uses them. Peace and quietude he holdeth high.	it not.
Even if the war is won, one should not glorify it.	Cannot be allowed to prevail in the empire.	One who exults in the killing of men will never have his way in the empire.	He conquers but rejoices not. Rejoicing at a conquest means to enjoy the slaughter of men. He who enjoys the slaughter of men will most assuredly not obtain his will in the empire.	One who beautifies [war] is one who delights in killing.
To glorify it means that one enjoys slaying men.	Hence, on auspicious occasions,	On occasions of rejoicing precedence is given to the left;		One who delights in killing is unfit to be entrusted with people of the world.
If one enjoys slaying men, one will never be successful in the world.	Precedence is given to the left;	On occasions of mourning precedence is given to the right.		On celebratory occasions, prefer left;
	In mourning,	A lieutenants place is on the left;		On sad occasions, prefer right.
	Precedence is given to the right.	The general's place is on the right.		The adjutant stays left;
	Hence, a lieutenant general stands left;	This means that it is mourning rites that are observed.		the commander-in-chief stays right.
	A senior general stands right,	When great numbers of people are killed, one should weep over them with sorrow.		Thus, treat war as funeral.
	Meaning it is handled with mourning rituals.	When victorious in war, one should observe the rites of mourning.		Those who have killed, return with remorse.
	If the number of men killed is multitudinous,			Treat victory as funeral.
	Preside over it in grief.			
	After winning a war,			
	Handle it with mourning rituals.			

Tao is real, yet unnameable. It is original non-differentiation and invisible. Nevertheless, nothing in the universe can dominate it. If rulers and lords were able to abide with it, all things in the universe would yield to them naturally. Heaven and earth are unified and rain the dew of peace. Without being ordered to	The Tao is constant and nameless. The unhewn log, though tiny, None under heaven dare subjugate. If marquises and kings can adhere to it, The ten thousand things will submit to them spontaneously. When heaven and earth integrate To drip sweet dew, Without anyone ordering them, It	The way is for ever nameless. Though the uncarved block is small No one in the world dare claim its allegiance. Should lords and princes be able to hold fast to it The myriad creatures will submit of their own accord, Heaven and earth will unite and sweet dew will fall, And the people will be	The Virtue of Holiness Reason, in its eternal aspect, is unnamable. Although its simplicity seems insignificant, the whole world does not dare to suppress it. If princes and kings could keep it, the ten thousand things would of themselves pay homage. Heaven and earth would unite in dripping sweet dew, and the people with no one to command them would of themselves be —	Direction frequently needs no name. It is simple. It is small. Still, it submits to nothing in the world. Were a Duke or a Prince to embrace Direction, myriad matters would submit on own volition. With the cosmos and the earth in harmony, sweet
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do so, people become harmonious by themselves. When discrimination begins, names arise. After names arise, one should know where to abide. When one knows where to abide, one is never exhausted. To abide with Tao in the world is to be the same as mountain streams flowing to the rivers and to the sea.	is evenly distributed spontaneously. With the first cutting, Names emerged. Names having emerged, One should also know where to stop. Knowing where to stop Will thereby exempt one from peril. The Tao's relation to all under heaven Is like small valley streams To a river or an ocean.	equitable, though no one so decrees. Only when it is cut are there names. As soon as there are names One ought to know that it is time to stop. Knowing when to stop one can be free from danger. The way is to the world as the River and the Sea are to rivulets and streams.	righteous. As soon as Reason creates order, it becomes namable. Whenever the namable in its turn acquires existence, one learns to know when to stop. By knowing when to stop, one avoids danger. To illustrate Reason's relation to the world we compare it to streams and creeks in their course towards rivers and the ocean.	dew accrues. It self-regulates without the need of intervention. As the system begins, names are assigned. When names are assigned, know when to stop. Knowing when to stop averts danger. Direction in relation to people of the world is like the sea to rivers.
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To know others is to be intelligent. To be aware of one's self is to be awakened. To overcome others is to have superior strength. To overcome one's self is to be vigorous.	He who knows others is crafty; He who knows himself is clear-sighted. He who overcomes others has strength; He who overcomes himself has stamina. He who	He who knows others is clever; He who knows himself has discernment. He who overcomes others has force; He who overcomes himself is strong. He who knows contentment is	The Virtue of Discrimination One who knows others is clever, but one who knows himself is enlightened. One who conquers others is powerful, but one who conquers himself is mighty. One	Knowing others is wisdom; knowing self is discernment. Winning over others shows prowess; winning over self shows strength. With contentment, one is
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To be satisfied is to be wealthy. To act with power is to be aspiring. To retain one's source is to be long-lasting. To die yet not to be deceased is to have longevity.	knows content is rich; He who practices strenuously achieves his aspiration; He who does not lose his base is long-enduring; He who dies without forgetting is long-lived.	rich; He who perseveres is a man of purpose; He who does not lose his station will endure; He who lives out his days has had a long life.	who knows contentment is rich and one who pushes with vigor has will. One who loses not his place endures. One who may die but will not perish, has life everlasting.	wealthy. With persistence, one shows determination. Holding on without losing ground, one is strong; Dying without giving up Direction, one lives long.
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The magnificent Tao is all-pervading.

It may penetrate to either this side or that side.

All creatures abide with it and grow; none are excluded from it.

When its work is done, it does not demand merit.

It nurtures all things, but does

How the Tao overflows!

It may be found left and right.

The ten thousand things relying on it for their living,

It does not decline;

Having scored successes,

It claims no possession;

Clothing and feeding the ten thousand things,

It does not assume masterdom;

Meaning it is constantly lustless,

And

The way is broad, reaching left as well as right.

The myriad creatures depend on it for life yet it claims no authority.

It accomplishes its task yet lays claim to no merit.

It clothes and feeds the myriad creatures yet lays no claim to being their

Trust in its Perfection

How all-pervading is the great Reason! It can be on the left and it can be on the right.

The ten thousand things depend upon it for their life, and it refuses them not.

When its merit is accomplished it assumes not the name.

The Grand Direction permeates, left and right.

With myriad matters depending on it for growth, it declines none.

Accomplishing much, it accepts no limelight.

Nurturing myriad

not rule them.

When it is without intention, it may be called lesser.

When all things return to it, yet it does not possess them, it may be called greater.

Therefore, the wise does not endeavor to be great.

Hence, his attainment is great.

may be named among the tiny.

When the ten thousand things return,

They do not know who their master is;

Hence, it may be named among the vast.

That is why the sage man

Was able to achieve vastness.

As he never assumed vastness,

He was able to achieve vastness.

master.

For ever free of desire, it can be called small;

Yet as it lays no claim to being master when the myriad creatures turn to it, it can be called great.

It is because it never attempts itself to become great that it succeeds in becoming great.

Lovingly it nourishes the ten thousand things and plays not the lord. Ever desireless it can be classed with the small. The ten thousand things return home to it. It plays not the lord. It can be classed with the great.

Therefore

The holy man unto death does not make himself great and can thus accomplish his greatness.

matters without claiming, it may be labeled Small;

Receiving myriad matters without claiming, it may be labeled Grand.

By not self-claiming Grand, it is thus Grand.

When one maintains
the great image in
dealing with the
world,

One deals with the
world without
harming it.

Instead, one makes
the world serene,
tranquil, and
peaceful.

Music and delicacies
may attract

Take hold of the
great image,

And all under heaven
will flock to you.

Once there,
unharméd,

They will settle down
in peace and
prosperity.

Music and pastries

Make the wayfarers

Have in your hold the
great image

And the empire will
come to you.

Coming to you and
meeting with no
harm

It will be safe and
sound.

Music and food

The Virtue of
Benevolence

"Who holdeth fast to
the great Form,

Of him the world will
come in quest:

For there we never
meet with harm,

There we find
shelter, comfort,
rest."

Music with dainties
makes the passing
stranger stop.

Whoever embraces
the Grand Image
attracts people in the
world.

Attracting but not
discriminating, they
live in peace.

Hearing music and
seeing food, visitors
linger.

Direction,

passersby to remain
momentarily,

But the taste of Tao
is plain and without
flavor.

Look at it, nothing
can be seen.

Listen to it, nothing
can be heard.

Employ it, it cannot
be depleted.

pause.

Therefore, when the
Tao utters words,

They say: "How
bland and tasteless!

Looked at,

It is not worth seeing;

Listened to,

Not worth hearing."

When used, however,

It is inexhaustible.

Will induce the
wayfarer to stop.

The way in its
passage through the
mouth is without
flavor.

It cannot be seen,

It cannot be heard,

Yet it cannot be
exhausted by use.

But Reason, when
coming from the
mouth, how tasteless
is it! It has no flavor.
When looked at,
there is not enough to
be seen; when
listened to, there is
not enough to be
heard. However,
when used, it is
inexhaustible.

[as a subject] for
discussion, is plain
and flavorless.

Looking at it, it is
invisible;

Listening to it, it is
inaudible;

using it, it is
inexhaustible.

That which is to be condensed must first be dispersed. That which is to be enervated must first be vitalized. That which is to be devastated must first be produced. That which is to be obtained must	That which shall contract Must have long expanded; That which shall weaken Must have long strengthened; That which shall depart Must have long partaken; That which shall take Must	If you would have a thing shrink, You must first stretch it; If you would have a thing weakened, You must first strengthen it; If you would have a thing laid aside, You must first set it up; If you would take from a	The Secret's Explanation That which is about to contract has surely been expanded. That which is about to weaken has surely been strengthened. That which is about to fall has surely been raised.	Before contracting [an object], let it expand; Before weakening [an object], let it solidify; Before abandoning [an object], let it flourish; Before seizing [an object], let it
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first be yielded. This is called invisible illumination. The soft overcomes the unshakable; The weak overcomes the strong. Just as fish stay deep in the pond, The best arms in the nation are those that remain invisible.	have long given. This is called subtle insight. Softness and weakness overcome strength: Fish cannot leap out of deep water; So cannot the state's sharp weapons Be displayed to men.	thing, You must first give to it. This is called subtle discernment: The submissive and weak will overcome the hard and strong. The fish must not be allowed to leave the deep; The instruments of power in a state must not be revealed to anyone.	That which is about to be despoiled has surely been endowed. This is an explanation of the secret that the tender and the weak conquer the hard and the strong. As the fish should not escape from the deep, so with the country's sharp tools the people should not become acquainted.	aggregate. This is discernment at its micro best. Tenderness overcomes brutality. Fish cannot survive away from water. A state does not boast her weaponry before the people.
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Tao is real and free from action, yet nothing is not acted upon.

If rulers abide with it, all things transmute by themselves.

If, in the process of transmutation, intention emerges, it must be overcome by the original non-differentiation of

The Tao is constant and nameless.

If marquises and kings can adhere to it,

The ten thousand things will live and grow spontaneously.

While they live and grow spontaneously,

If lusts

The way never acts, yet nothing is left undone.

Should lords and princes be able to hold fast to it,

The myriad creatures will be transformed of their own accord.

After they are transformed, should desire raise its head,

I

Administration of Government

Reason always practises non-assertion, and there is nothing that remains undone.

If princes and kings could keep Reason, the ten thousand creatures would of themselves be reformed.

Direction is laissez-faire at all times; it is all-permeating.

Were a Duke or a Prince to govern with Direction,

Myriad matters would develop on own volition.

As self-development

the nameless.

To experience the original non-differentiation of the nameless, one should also be free from intending to have no-intention.

To be free from intending to have no-intention is to be quiescent.

Thereby, the world is naturally led to tranquillity.

arise,

I shall fill them with the nameless unhewn log.

Being filled with the nameless unhewn log,

They shall become lustless.

Lustlessness leads to stillness;

Heaven and earth shall turn aright spontaneously.

shall press it down with the weight of the nameless uncarved block.

The nameless uncarved block

Is but freedom from desire,

And if I cease to desire and remain still,

The empire will be at peace of its own accord.

While being reformed they might yet be anxious to stir; but I would restrain them by the simplicity of the Ineffable.

"The simplicity of the unexpressed

Will purify the heart of lust.

Is there no lust there will be rest,

And all the world will thus be blest."

degenerates into avarice in complexity,

I suppress it with Direction's simplicity.

Suppressing with Direction's simplicity,

avarice disappears.

Without avarice, serenity visits with ease;

The world self-governs in peace.

The highest attainment (Tê) is free from attainment.

Therefore, there is attainment.

The lowest attainment is never free from attainment.

Therefore, there is no attainment.

The highest attainment never acts and is purposeless.

The lowest attainment acts and is purposeful.

The highest benevolence (jen) acts and is purposeless.

The highest righteousness (yi) acts and is purposeful.

The highest propriety (li) acts and no one follows it.

One bares one's arms and throws one's opponents away.

Therefore, when Tao

The man of supreme virtue
Claimed no virtue,
Hence, he possessed virtue;
The man of the lowest virtue
Would not lose virtue,
Hence, he possessed no
virtue.

The man of supreme virtue
did not act,
And had no intention to act;
The man of supreme
humanity acted,
But had no intention to act;
The man of supreme
righteousness acted,
And had the intention to act;
The man of supreme rituals
acted,
And as none responded to
him,
He rolled up his sleeves to
drag them along.
Hence, only

A man of the highest virtue does not keep to virtue and that is why he has virtue.

A man of the lowest virtue never strays from virtue and that is why he is without virtue.

The former never acts yet leaves nothing undone.

The latter acts but there are things left undone.

A man of the highest benevolence acts, but from no ulterior motive.

A man of the highest rectitude acts, but from ulterior motive.

A man most conversant in the rites acts, but when no one responds rolls up his sleeves and resorts to persuasion by

Discourse on Virtue

Superior virtue is unvirtue. Therefore it has virtue. Inferior virtue never loses sight of virtue. Therefore it has no virtue.

Superior virtue is non-assertion and without pretension. Inferior virtue asserts and makes pretensions.

Superior benevolence acts but makes no pretensions. Superior justice acts and makes pretensions.

Superior propriety acts and when no one responds to it, it stretches its arm and enforces its rules.

Thus one loses Reason and then virtue appears.

By not displaying one's high virtue, one is virtuous;

By parading one's little virtue, one is not virtuous.

One with high virtue follows laissez-faire with carefree ease;

One with little virtue follows laissez-faire to parade one's virtue.

One with high nobleness practices nobleness with carefree ease;

One with high righteousness practices righteousness to parade one's righteousness.

One with high Conduct decrees;

With no followers, one uses force to twist others into following.

Thus,

virtue comes to the fore when Direction is not in

is lost, we have attainment.
When attainment is lost, we have benevolence.
When benevolence is lost, we have righteousness.
When righteousness is lost, we have propriety.
Propriety is due to a lack of trustworthiness and is the beginning of disorder.
Anticipated knowledge is the superficiality of Tao and is the beginning of foolishness.
Hence, the great man chooses reality and not superficiality.
He acts according to reality and not appearance.
Thus, he grasps the one and foregoes the other.

force.
Hence when the way was
lost there was virtue;
When virtue was lost
there was benevolence;
When benevolence was
lost there was rectitude;
When rectitude was lost
there were the rites.
The rites are the wearing
thin of loyalty and good
faith
And the beginning of
disorder;
Foreknowledge is the
flowery embellishment of
the way
And the beginning of
folly.
Hence the man of large
mind abides in the thick
not in the thin, in the fruit
not in the flower.

One loses virtue and then benevolence appears. One loses benevolence and then justice appears. One loses justice and then propriety appears. The rules of propriety are the semblance of loyalty and faith, and the beginning of disorder.

Traditionalism is the flower of Reason, but of ignorance the beginning.

Therefore a great organizer abides by the solid and dwells not in the external. He abides in the fruit and dwells not in the flower.

Therefore he discards the latter and chooses the former.

evidence,
nobleness comes to the fore
when virtue is not in
evidence,
righteousness comes to the
fore when nobleness is not in
evidence,
Conduct comes to the fore
when righteousness is not in
evidence.
Conduct comes to the fore
when loyalty and
trustworthiness lack;
it brings about confusion.
Foreknowledge addresses but
Direction's superficialities;
it initiates folly.
Thus,
a great man seeks fullness,
not lack;
seeks substance, not facade.

In the remote past there were those who attained the One. Attaining the One, heaven became pure. Attaining the One, earth became peaceful. Attaining the One, God became spiritual. Attaining the One, the ocean became full. Attaining the One, ten thousand things came into life. Attaining the One, rulers became the models of the world. All of them became so through the One. Without becoming pure, heaven would have broken. Without becoming peaceful, the earth would have quaked. Without becoming spiritual, God would have crumbled. Without becoming full, the ocean would	Long, long ago, those that acquired One were: Heaven, which acquired One And thereby became clear; Earth, which acquired One And thereby became tranquil; Spirits, which acquired One And thereby became miraculous; Valley streams, which acquired One And thereby became full; Marquises and kings, who acquired One And thereby became chieftains over all under heaven. Going to the extreme would mean: If heaven were excessively clear, It would crack; If earth were excessively tranquil,	Of old, these came to be in possession of the One: Heaven in virtue of the One is limpid; Earth in virtue of the One is settled; Gods in virtue of the One have their potencies; The valley in virtue of the One is full; The myriad creatures in virtue of the One are alive; Lords and princes in virtue of the One become leaders of the empire. It is the One that makes these what they are. Without what makes it limpid heaven might split; Without what makes it settled earth might sink; Without what gives	The Root of Order From of old these things have obtained oneness: "Heaven by oneness becometh pure. Earth by oneness can endure. Minds by oneness souls procure. Valleys by oneness repletion secure. "All creatures by oneness to life have been called. And kings were by oneness as models installed." Such is the result of oneness. "Were heaven not pure it might be rent. Were earth not stable it might be bent. Were minds not ensouled they'd be impotent.	Among those with One in the past: The cosmos, with One, produced cleanliness; The earth, with One, produced calmness; A shen, with One, produced responsiveness; The valley, with One, produced fullness; Myriad matters, with One, generated; A Duke or Prince, with One, at the center of the world was seated. Extending, The cosmos, without One and without cleanliness, would be separated; The earth, without One and without calmness, would be barren; A shen, without One and without responsiveness, would be deserted; The valley, without One
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have drained. Without coming into life, ten thousand things would have perished. Without becoming the models of the world, rulers would have stumbled. Therefore, the worthless serves as the foundation of the worthy. The inferior serves as the basis of the superior. Thus, rulers call themselves isolated men, without merit, and worthless. Is this not enough to prove that the worthless serve as the foundation of the worthy? Hence, the perfect fame is no fame. Rulers do not want to be esteemed as tingling jade; they would rather be plain, solid rock.	— — — — — — — — — — — — — — — — — — — —	themselves; Without what makes it full the valley might run dry; Without what keeps them alive the myriad creatures might perish; Without what makes them leaders lords and princes might fall. Hence the superior must have the inferior as root; The high must have the low as base. Thus lords and princes refer to themselves as 'solitary', 'desolate', and 'hapless'. This is taking the inferior as root, is it not? Hence the highest renown is without renown, Not wishing to be one among many like jade	creatures are lifeless who can their death prevent? Are kings not models, but on haughtiness bent, Their fall, forsooth, is imminent." Thus, the nobles come from the commoners as their root, and the high rest upon the lowly as their foundation. Therefore, princes and kings call themselves orphaned, lonely, and unworthy. Is this not because they take lowliness as their root? The several parts of a carriage are not a carriage. Those who have become a unity are neither anxious to be praised with praise like a gem, nor disdained with disdain like a stone.	and without fullness, would be depleted; Myriad matters, without One and without growth, would stall; Dukes and princes, without One and without being in the center, would fall. Thus, humbleness is the root of esteem; lowness is the foundation of height. Thus, a Duke or Prince calls himself My Loneliness, The Isolated Person, The Ungracious Person. Is this not humbleness as the root of esteem? Is it not so? Thus, the supreme honor requires no honor. Aim not at jade's attractiveness, but at rock's solidness.
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Reverse is the movement of Tao.
Yielding is the action of Tao.

Ten

Opposition characterizes the Tao's movement;

Weakness characterizes the Tao's function.

All

Turning back is how the way moves;

Weakness is the means the way employs.

Avoiding Activity

"Homeward is Reason's course,
Weakness is Reason's force."

Heaven and earth

Periodicity is Direction in motion;

Frailty is Direction in application.

Myriad matters in

thousand things in the universe are created from being.

Being is created from non-being.

things under heaven are generated from being;

Being is generated from nonbeing.

The myriad creatures in the world are born from

Something, and Something from Nothing.

and the ten thousand things come from existence, but existence comes from non-existence.

the world are born out of Ull.

Ull is born out of Null.

When a man of superior talent listens to Tao, he earnestly applies it. When an ordinary man listens to Tao, he seems to believe it and yet not to believe it. When the worst man listens to Tao, he greatly ridicules it. If he did not ridicule it, it would not be Tao. Therefore, in Ch'ien-yen we have: Understand Tao as if you do not understand it; Enter into Tao as if you are coming out of it; Move smoothly with Tao as if you are	When the superior scholar hears the Tao, He does his utmost to practice it; When the middling scholar hears the Tao, It seems existent, seems non-existent; When the inferior scholar hears the Tao, He bursts out laughing. If he did not burst out laughing, It would not deserve to be the Tao. Hence, "Established Sayings" has it: "The clear Tao seems obscure; The advancing Tao	When the best student hears about the way He practises it assiduously; When the average student hears about the way It seems to him there one moment and gone the next; When the worst student hears about the way He laughs out loud. If he did not laugh It would be unworthy of being the way. Hence the Chien yen has it: The way that is bright seems dull; The way that is forward seems to lead back — wa — r — d —	Sameness in Difference When a superior scholar hears of Reason he endeavors to practise it. When an average scholar hears of Reason he will sometimes keep it and sometimes lose it. When an inferior scholar hears of Reason he will greatly ridicule it. Were it not thus ridiculed, it would as Reason be insufficient. Therefore the poet says: "The Reason--enlightened seem dark and black, The Reason--advanced seem going back, The Reason--straight-levelled seem rugged and slack.	Hearing Direction, a scholar with high intelligence follows it with diligence; a scholar with average intelligence greets it with mixed seriousness and doubt; a scholar with low intelligence ridicules it. Direction will not be Direction without being ridiculed. It is said: A bright Direction appears unilluminating; An advancing Direction appears retreating; A straight-forward Direction appears uninviting; Highest
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having difficulties. The highest attainment is as if it is no attainment. All-embracing attainment is as if it is lacking attainment. Rigorous attainment is as if it is indolent loafing. Real essence is as if it is empty. The great white is as if it is black. The great square is without corners. Great capacity is successful in its later days. Great music is without sound. The great image is without form. Tao is concealed and without name. Nevertheless, Tao furnishes all things and fulfills them.	seems receding; The even Tao seems rugged; Supreme virtue is like a valley; Great white seems black; Abundant virtue seems deficient; Robust virtue seems flabby; Honest truth seems capricious; The great square has no corners; The great vessel is imperfect; The great voice has no sound; The celestial image has no form." The Tao is invisible and nameless; The Tao alone Begins well and ends well.	The way that is even seems rough. The highest virtue is like the valley; The sheerest whiteness seems sullied; Ample virtue seems defective; Vigorous virtue seems indolent; Plain virtue seems soiled; The great square has no corners. The great vessel takes long to complete; The great note is rarefied in sound; The great image has no shape. The way conceals itself in being nameless. It is the way alone that excels in bestowing and in accomplishing.	vale, The purely white in shame must quail, The staunchest virtue seems to fail. "The solidest virtue seems not alert, The purest chastity seems pervers, The greatest square will rightness desert. "The largest vessel is not yet complete, The loudest sound is not speech replete, The greatest form has no shape concrete." Reason so long as it remains latent is unnamable. Yet Reason alone is good for imparting and completing.	virtue appears as valley impoverished; Purest white appears blemished; Broadest virtue appears diminished; Strong virtue appears slack; Fine quality appears flawed; The supreme square has no corners; The supreme vessel is cast last; The supreme sound is inaudible; The supreme image is formless. Direction is unrevealed and anonymous.
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From the Tao, one is created; From one, two; From two, three; From three, ten thousand things. All of them achieve harmony through the unification of affirmation and negation Which is embraced by everything. No one likes to be isolated (ku), without merit (kua), or worthless (pu ku), Yet rulers	The Tao generated one; One generated two; Two generated three; Three generated the ten thousand things. The ten thousand things, Carrying yin and embracing yang, Used the empty vapor to achieve harmony. What people loathe most are Inadequacy, deficiency and unworthiness, Yet, kings	The way begets one; One begets two; Two begets three; Three begets the myriad creatures. The myriad creatures carry on their backs the yin and embrace in their arms the yang and are the blending of the generative forces of the two. There are no words which men detest more than	Reason's Modifications Reason begets unity; unity begets duality; duality begets trinity; and trinity begets the ten thousand things. The ten thousand things are sustained by Yin [the negative principle]; they are encompassed by Yang [the positive principle], and the immaterial breath renders them harmonious. That which the people find odious, to be orphaned, lonely, and unworthy, kings and princes select as their titles.	From Direction, One is born. From One, Two is born. From Two, Three is born. From Three, myriad matters are born. Myriad matters turn their backs on yin and embrace yang. The complement of their energy produces harmony. What people dislike are loneliness, isolation, and
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refer to themselves with these names. Thus, some things add to their value by reducing their value. Some things reduce their value by adding to their value. Other ancients have taught this; I teach it too. "The man of violence will end his life in violence." This is a basic motto.	and dukes use them To refer to themselves. People sometimes gain through losing; Sometimes lose through gaining. Therefore, what kings teach, I also choose to teach kings: "A brute does not die a natural death." I shall use it as the father of learning.	'solitary', 'desolate', and 'hapless', yet lords and princes use these to refer to themselves. Thus a thing is sometimes added to by being diminished and diminished by being added to. What others teach I also teach. "The violent shall not come to a natural end." I shall take this as my precept.	Thus, on the one hand, loss implies gain, and on the other hand, gain implies loss. What others have taught I teach also. The strong and aggressive do not die a natural death; but I will obey the doctrine's father.	ungraciousness, yet this is how Dukes and Princes self-address. Thus, a matter expands through contraction; contracts through expansion. This is what others have taught me; let me teach others the same: "A violent person does not die in place." This is the theme of my teaching.
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The meekest in the world Penetrates the strongest in the world. As nothingness enters into that-which-has-no-opening Hence, I am aware of the value	The softest under heaven Gallops over the hardest under heaven; The formless penetrates into the spaceless. I thereby know	Exterminate learning, and there will no longer be worries. The most submissive thing in the world can ride roughshod over the hardest in the world; That which is without substance entering that which has no crevices. That	Its Universal Application The world's weakest overcomes the world's hardest. Non-existence enters into the impenetrable. Thereby I comprehend of non-assertion the advantage.	The world's tenderest is the master of the world's steeliest. Null permeates Ull. I thus know the benefits
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of non-action And of the value of teaching with no words, As for the value of non-action, Nothing in the world can match it.	the benefit of nonaction. The edification of speechlessness The benefit of nonaction - Nothing under heaven can match it.	is why I know the benefit of resorting to no action. The teaching that uses no words, the benefit of resorting to no action, these are beyond the understanding of all but a very few in the world.	There are few in the world who obtain of non-assertion the advantage and of silence the lesson.	of laissez-faire. Instructions without words and benefits of laissez-faire - few things in the world can top them.
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Man's name or man's self - which is closer to him? Man's self or his property - which is more valuable to him? Success or failure - which is more harmful to him? Things that are cherished more, cost	Fame and life - which is dearer? Life and wealth - which is weightier? Gain and loss - which is drearier? Excessive love entails enormous costs;	Your name or your person, Which is dearer? Your person or your goods, Which is worth more? Gain or loss, Which is a greater bane? That is why excessive meanness Is sure to lead to	Setting Up Precepts "Name or person, which is more near? Person or fortune, which is more dear? Gain or loss, which is more sear? "Extreme	Fame and health - which is dearer? Health and wealth - which is more valuable? Gain and loss - which is more damaging? Excessive love
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more. The more that is kept, the more that is missed. The man who is easily contented is free from shame. The man who knows the right time to stop is free from danger. Thus, he will last long.	Abundant stores entail heavy losses. Therefore, knowing content Will exempt you from humiliation; Knowing where to stop Will exempt you from peril. You may long endure.	great expense; Too much store Is sure to end in immense loss. Know contentment And you will suffer no disgrace; Know when to stop And you will meet with no danger. You can then endure.	dotage leadeth to squandering. Hoarded wealth inviteth plundering. "Who is content incurs no humiliation, Who knows when to stop risks no vitiation, Forever lasteth his duration."	demands large outlay. Overabundant wealth results in heavy loss. Thus, knowing contentment brings about no disgrace; knowing moderation brings about no danger. One lasts long.
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When accomplishment reaches its utmost,
It is as if nothing is accomplished.
Its application is never exhausted.
When fullness reaches its utmost,
It is as if it is still vacant.
Its application leads to limitlessness.
Thus the perfectly straight

Great perfection seems imperfect -
Its function is unfailing;
Great fullness seems empty -
Its function is inexhaustible.
Great straightness seems bent;
Great eloquence seems

Great perfection seems chipped,
Yet use will not wear it out;
Great fullness seems empty,
Yet use will not drain it;
Great straightness seems bent;

Greatest Virtue
"Greatest perfection imperfect will be,
But its work ne'er waneth.
Greatest fulness is vacuity,
Its work unexhausted remaineth."
"Straightest lines resemble curves;

Great Perfection appears flawed; its use is endless.
Great Fullness appears less; its use is limitless.
Great Straightness appears warped,

is as if it were bent.
The most skilled is as if it were stupid.
The greatest ability of debate is as if it were speechless.
Hence, quiescence surpasses movement,
Coldness surpasses heat,
Tranquillity sets the example for the world.

tongue-tied;
Great adroitness seems clumsy;
Great affluence seems deficient.
Restlessness overcomes cold;
Stillness overcomes heat.
Emptiness and stillness
May serve as the norm of the empire.

Great skill seems awkward;
Great eloquence seems tongue-tied.
Restlessness overcomes cold;
Stillness overcomes heat.
Limpid and still,
One can be a leader in the empire.

Greatest skill like a tyro serves;
Greatest eloquence stammers and swerves."
Motion conquers cold. Quietude conquers heat. Purity and clearness are the world's standard.

Great Dexteriousness appears handicapped,
Great Eloquence appears reticent.
Serenity wins over rashness; coolness wins over heatedness.
Serenity governs the world.

When the world is governed according to Tao,

Horses are used to work on the farm.

When the world is not governed according to Tao,

Horses and weapons are produced for the frontier.

No

When the empire possessed the Tao,

Gallop horses were turned back to manure the fields;

When the empire has lost the Tao,

War-horses are bred on the frontier.

No crime is

When the way prevails in the empire, fleet-footed horses are relegated to ploughing in the fields;

When the way does not prevail in the empire, war-horses breed on the border.

There is no

Moderation of Desire

When the world possesses Reason, race horses are reserved for hauling dung.

When the world is governed by Direction, horses haul manure.

When the world is not governed by Direction, mares foal near [war] location.

No calamity is greater

crime is greater than that of ambition.

No misfortune is greater than that of discontentment.

No fault is greater than that of conquering.

Therefore, to know contentment through contentment

Is to always have enough.

greater than indulging in greed;

No misfortune is greater than not knowing content;

No catastrophe is more grievous than thirsting for gain.

Therefore, the content of knowing content

Makes one constantly content.

crime greater than having too many desires;

There is no disaster greater than not being content;

There is no misfortune greater than being covetous.

Hence in being content, one will always have enough.

When the world is without Reason, war horses are bred in the common.

No greater sin than yielding to desire. No greater misery than discontent. No greater calamity than greed.

Therefore, he who knows content's content is always content.

than not being content;

No fault is greater than the desire to gain at any cost.

Thus, one who is content in being content is always content.

Without going out of
the gate,
One is aware of the
world.
Without peering
outside,
One sees the way of
heaven.
The farther away one
is,
The less

Without leaving the
door,
You may know
everything under
heaven;
Without peeping
through the window,
You may know
heaven's Tao.
The

Without stirring
abroad
One can know the
whole world;
Without looking out
the window
One can see the way
of heaven.
The further

Viewing the Distant
"Without passing out
of the gate
The world's course I
prognosticate.
Without peeping
through the window
The heavenly Reason
I contemplate.
The further one goes,
The less one

Without leaving
home, one knows the
world;
Without looking
through the window,
one discerns the
cosmos's Direction.
The farther one
moves

one is aware.
Therefore, the wise is
aware of all things
Without moving a
step.
He identifies all
things
Without looking at
them.
He completes all
things
Without action.

farther you venture
abroad,
The less you know.
Hence, the sage man
Knew without
traveling,
Understood without
seeing,
Accomplished
without acting.

one goes
The less one knows.
Therefore the sage
knows without
having to stir,
Identifies without
having to see,
Accomplishes
without having to act.

knows."
Therefore the holy
man does not travel,
and yet he has
knowledge. He does
not see things, and
yet he defines them.
He does not labor,
and yet he completes.

about, the less one
knows.
Thus,
the sage knows
without moving
about,
discerns without
looking through the
window,
accomplishes with
laissez-faire.

To learn, One accumulates day by day. To study Tao, One reduces day by day. Through reduction and further reduction One reaches non-action,	He who pursues learning daily increases; He who hears the Tao daily decreases. He decreases and decreases Until he acts not And has no intention to	In the pursuit of learning one knows more every day; In the pursuit of the way one does less every day. One does less and less until one does nothing at all, and when one	Forgetting Knowledge He who seeks learnedness will daily increase. He who seeks Reason will daily diminish. He will diminish and continue to diminish until he arrives at non-assertion. With non-assertion there is nothing that he cannot achieve.	Aiming at study, one's avarice gains day by day; Aiming at Direction, one's avarice loses day by day. Losing [avarice] upon losing [avarice],
And everything is acted upon. Therefore, one often wins over the world Through non-action. Through action, one may not win over the world.	act. He who wishes to win all under heaven Never creates disturbances. If he creates disturbances, He is no longer fit to win all under heaven.	does nothing at all there is nothing that is undone. It is always through not meddling that the empire is won. Should you meddle, then you are not equal to the task of winning the empire.	When he takes the empire, it is always because he uses no diplomacy. He who uses diplomacy is not fit to take the empire.	one ends with laissez-faire. Laissez-faire permeates everything. To govern the world, one always practices laissez-faire. Without laissez-faire, one is unfit to govern the world.

The wise man is free from his own mind, But identifies the people's minds as mind. He considers good as good, But he also considers not-good as good. Thus, his attainment of non-differentiation is successful. He considers truth as truth, But	The sage man never had a predisposed heart, Taking the hundred family's heart To be the concern of his heart. Good people - he was good to them; Evil people - he was also good to them. Goodness was attained. Honest people - he was honest to them;	The sage has no mind of his own. He takes as his own the mind of the people. Those who are good I treat as good. Those who are not good I also treat as good. In so doing I gain in goodness. Those who are of good faith I have faith in. Those	Trust in Virtue The holy man has not a heart of his own. The hundred families' hearts he makes his heart. The good I meet with goodness; the bad I also meet with goodness; that is virtue's goodness.	The sage has no preconceived notion at any time; the people's notion is the sage's notion. I treat a person, who is good, well; I treat a person, who is not good, also well. This is for goodness's sake. I trust a person who
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he also considers not-truth as truth. Thus, his attainment of non-differentiation is perfected. In the world, the wise conscientiously non-differentiates The minds of the people. Because people rely on their senses of hearing and seeing, The wise treats them as innocent children.	Dishonest people - he was also honest to them. Honesty was attained. When the sage man presided over the empire, Unbiased, he muddled their hearts For all under heaven. The hundred family names All lent him their ears and eyes; The sage man turned them all into infants.	who are lacking in good faith I also have faith in. In so doing I gain in good faith. The sage in his attempt to distract the mind of the empire seeks urgently to muddle it. The people all have something to occupy their eyes and ears, and the sage treats them all like children.	The faithful I meet with faith; the faithless I also meet with faith; that is virtue's faith. The holy man dwells in the world anxious, very anxious in his dealings with the world. He universalizes his heart, and the hundred families fix upon him their ears and eyes. The holy man treats them all like children.	is worthy of trust; I also trust a person who is not worthy of trust. This is for trustworthiness's sake. The sage, in governing the world, holds back personal notions in favor of the people's. The sage treats the people, focusing on themselves, as infants.
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To live or to die: Three out of ten men live, While three out of ten men die. Further, three out of ten men cling to life, But they lose it. Why? Because they all crave life. He who knows how	People emerge into life and enter into death. The category of life constitutes three tenths; The category of death constitutes three tenths; And those who, seeking extravagant living, All move to the realm of death Also constitute three tenths. Why so? Because they seek extravagant living. I hear that those who excel in preserving	When going one way means life and going the other means death, three in ten will be comrades in life, three in ten will be comrades in death, and there are those who value life and as a result move into the realm of death, and these also number three in ten. Why is this so? Because they set too much store by life. I have heard it said that one	The Estimation of Life Abroad in life, home in death. There are thirteen avenues of life; there are thirteen avenues of death; on thirteen avenues men that live pass unto the realm of death. Now, what is the reason? It is because they live life's intensity.	People are born and people die. Three in ten live long; Three in ten die young; Three in ten move [prematurely] into death's realm. Why so? Because they care for their lives too well. Those who care for themselves, it is said, are unlikely to encounter rhinoceroses
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to safeguard his life Does not encounter tigers or rhinoceroses. In the battlefield He does not avoid dangerous weapons. Rhinoceroses cannot gore him, Tigers cannot claw him, Dangerous weapons cannot harm him. Why? Because there is no place in him for death.	life, Walking in mountains, Shun neither rhinoceros nor tiger; Entering a battle, Incur wounds from neither weapon nor armor. The rhinoceros has nowhere to thrust its horn; The tiger has nowhere to press its claws; Weapons have nowhere to lodge their blades. Why so? Because they do not belong to the realm of death.	who excels in safeguarding his own life does not meet with rhinoceros or tiger when travelling on land nor is he touched by weapons when charging into an army. There is nowhere for the rhinoceros to pitch its horn; There is nowhere for the tiger to place its claws; There is nowhere for the weapon to lodge its blade. Why is this so? Because for him there is no realm of death.	When coming among soldiers, he need not fear arms and weapons. The rhinoceros finds no place wherein to insert its horn. The tiger finds no place wherein to put his claws. Weapons find no place wherein to thrust their blades. The reason is that he does not belong to the realm of death.	or tigers on land, or face weaponry and soldiers in war. Rhinoceroses have no occasion to use their horns; tigers have no occasion to use their claws; soldiers have no occasion to use their bayonets. Why so? Because they care for themselves to not move into death's realm.
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Tao creates all things; Tê cultivates them. Things are shaped according to their natures; Relational conditions fulfill them. Therefore, ten thousand things all venerate the source of Tao And value the potentialities of Tê. Tao is venerated and Tê is valued spontaneously; No one orders that it be so.	The Tao generates them, Virtue nurtures them, Matter forms them, And instruments complete them. Hence, the ten thousand things Honor the Tao and treasure virtue. That the Tao is honored And virtue is treasured is not because Anyone has conferred titles upon them;	The way gives them life; Virtue rears them; Things give them shape; Circumstances bring them to maturity. Therefore the myriad creatures all revere the way and honor virtue. Yet the way is revered and virtue honored not because this is decreed by any authority but because it is natural for them to be treated	Nursing Virtue Reason quickens all creatures. Virtue feeds them. Reality shapes them. The forces complete them. Therefore among the ten thousand things there is none that does not esteem Reason and honor virtue. Since the esteem of Reason and the honoring of virtue is by no one commanded, it is	Cultivated by Direction, reared by virtue; formed by matter, completed by interaction. Thus, myriad matters revere Direction and value virtue. The reason Direction is revered and virtue valued is that they do
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Tê cultivates them. They give them birth. They nourish them. They give them shape. They give them quality. They shelter them. They guard them. They create them but do not possess them. They work for them but expect no reward. They bring them to maturity but do not control them. This is called invisible attainment.	It is constantly the way things are. The Tao generates them, Nurtures them, Grows them, Raises them, Shapes them, Solidifies them, Stores them, Covers them. It generates without possessing, Assists without taking credit, Leads without dominating.	so. Thus the way gives them life and rears them; Brings them up and nurses them; Brings them to fruition and maturity; Feeds and shelters them. It gives them life yet claims no possession; It benefits them yet exacts no gratitude; It is the steward yet exercises no authority. Such is called the mysterious virtue.	forever spontaneous. Therefore it is said that Reason quickens all creatures, while virtue feeds them, raises them, nurtures them, completes them, matures them, rears them, and protects them. To quicken but not to own, to make but not to claim, to raise but not to rule, this is called profound virtue.	not command but let myriad matters visit Nature. Thus, Direction cultivates, virtue rears, nurtures, guides, comforts, protects, cares, shelters. Cultivating without possessing, providing without claiming, nurturing without dominating, This is the Profoundest Virtue.
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The world has its beginning, Which may be called the origin of the world. When one is aware of the origin, One knows its manifestations. When one is aware of its manifestations, Yet abides with its origin, One never falls short in all of one's life. Ceasing verbal expressions, Stopping the entry of sensations, One —	All under heaven have a beginning, Which is considered the mother of all under heaven. Having found their mother, You thereby know her children. Having known her children, You revert and adhere to their mother, A lifetime without peril. Stop your hole, Close your	The world had a beginning And this beginning could be the mother of the world. When you know the mother Go on to know the child. After you have known the child Go back to holding fast to the mother, And to the end of your days you will not meet with danger. Block the openings, Shut the doors, And all	Returning to the Origin When the world takes its beginning, Reason becomes the world's mother. As one knows his mother, so she in turn knows her child; as she quickens her child, so he in turn keeps to his mother, and to the end of life he is not in danger.	The world has a beginning; it is the mother to the world. By knowing the mother, one knows her children. By knowing the children, one returns to their mother. One is without danger in life. Stuffing channels to block portals [to avarice], one
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is never exhausted. On the contrary, when one is full of words And entangled with one's affairs, One is never able to save one's self. To see what is invisible is to be awakened. To remain gentle is to be strong. Apply illumination and return to awakening. Then one is free from disaster.	door, A lifetime without end. Open your hole, Increase your disturbances, A lifetime without remedy. Seeing tiny things is clear-sightedness. Adhering to softness is strength. Use its light, Withdraw your own clear-sightedness, And you shall bring yourself no calamity.	your life you will not run dry. Unblock the openings, Add to your troubles, And to the end of your days you will be beyond salvation. To see the small is called discernment; To hold fast to the submissive is called strength. Use the light But give up the discernment. Bring not misfortune upon yourself.	Who closes his mouth, and shuts his sense-gates, in the end of life he will encounter no trouble; but who opens his mouth and meddles with affairs, in the end of life he cannot be saved. Who beholds his smallness is called enlightened. Who preserves his tenderness is called strong. Who uses Reason's light and returns home to its enlightenment does not surrender his person to perdition. This is called practising the eternal.	is without concern in life. Opening channels to facilitate contact [with avarice], one is without hope in life. Seeing the tiniest is discernment. Holding onto tenderness is strength. Use one's light, reflect upon one's discernment, leave nothing to one's regret. This is Eternal Direction.
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If I had even a slight awareness,
And practiced the great Way,
What I would fear would be deviating from it.
The great Way is a very level road,
But men like to take circuitous paths.
Thus, the palaces are extremely elegant,
But the people's

Were I but firmly enlightened,
Walking along the great Tao,
My only fear would be going astray.
The great Tao is exceedingly even,
But the sovereign is exceedingly fond of gullies.
While the court is exceedingly well-kept,
The fields are exceedingly weedy,
And

Were I possessed of the least knowledge,
I would, when walking on the great way, fear only paths that lead astray.
The great way is easy, yet people prefer by-paths.
The court is corrupt,
The fields are overgrown with weeds,
The

Gaining Insight
If I have ever so little knowledge, I shall walk in the great Reason. It is but expansion that I must fear.
The great Reason is very plain, but people are fond of by-paths.
When the palace is very splendid,

This little I know:
In moving toward the Grand Direction, the only fear is moving astray.
The Grand Direction is straight forward; still, people go astray.
The court is not filled; the field

farms are extremely desolate,
And there is no grain reserved in the storehouses.
The rulers wear expensive garments,
Carry fine swords,
Sate themselves with food and drink,
And possess inordinate riches and precious things.
This is the greatest robbery,
And is indeed against the great Way.

the granaries exceedingly empty.
Clad in elegant and colorful attire,
Wearing a sharp sword,
And sated with food,
He has enough wealth and to spare.
Such a man is called the chieftain of bandits;
Being the chieftain of bandits goes against the Tao.

granaries are empty;
Yet there are those dressed in fineries,
With swords at their sides,
Filled with food and drink,
And possessed of too much wealth.
This is known as taking the lead in robbery.
Far indeed is this from the way.

the fields are very weedy and granaries very empty.
To wear ornaments and gay clothes, to carry sharp swords, to be excessive in drinking and eating, to have a redundancy of costly articles, this is the pride of robbers.
Surely, this is un-Reason.

is not tilled.
Storehouses are empty, but gorgeous gowns are aplenty.
Bearing sharp swords, tired of exquisite boards,
With wealth to the burst, they are bandits at their worst.
This is not Direction.

Nothing can be taken away if it is well-founded. Nothing can be lost if it is well-grasped. For generations to come, the worship will not be discontinued. To cultivate (Tao) in one's self makes attainment real. To cultivate (Tao) in one's family makes attainment a surplus. To cultivate (Tao) in one's community makes attainment long-lasting. To cultivate (Tao) in one's	He who excels in planting something - Nobody can pull it up; He who excels in embracing something - Nobody can snatch it away. His offspring will thereby offer sacrifices without end. Cultivate it in your own person, Your virtue will be genuine; Cultivate it in your own fief, Your virtue will be more than enough; Cultivate it in your own prefecture,	What is firmly rooted cannot be pulled out; What is tightly held in the arms will not slip loose; Through this the offering of sacrifice by descendants will never come to an end. Cultivate it in your person And its virtue will be genuine; Cultivate it in the family And its virtue will be more than sufficient; Cultivate it in the hamlet And its virtue will endure; Cultivate it	The Cultivation of Intuition "What is well planted is not uprooted; What's well preserved can not be looted!" By sons and grandsons the sacrificial celebrations shall not cease. Who cultivates Reason in his person, his virtue is genuine. Who cultivates it in his house, his virtue is overflowing. Who cultivates it in his township, his virtue is lasting.	What is well planted will not uproot; What is firmly held will not drop. Descendants will not discontinue remembrance ceremonies. Cultivating it in self, virtue is true; Cultivating it in the family, virtue overflows; Cultivating it in the village, virtue lasts; Cultivating it in the state, virtue is abundant; Cultivating
nation makes attainment abundant. To cultivate (Tao) in one's world makes attainment all-embracing. Thus, through the self, one contemplates the self. Through the family, one contemplates the family. Through the community, one contemplates the community. Through the nation, one contemplates the nation. Through the world, one contemplates the world. How do I know the world as world?	Cultivate it in your own state, Your virtue will be abundant; Cultivate it in the empire, Your virtue will be universal. Observe other persons from your own person; Observe other fiefs from your own fief; Observe other prefectures from your own prefecture; Observe other states from your own state; Observe the empire from all under heaven. How do I know what the empire is like?	in the state And its virtue will abound; Cultivate it in the empire And its virtue will be pervasive. Hence look at the person through the person; Look at the family through the family; Look at the hamlet through the hamlet; Look at the state through the state; Look at the empire through the empire. How do I know that the empire is like that? By means of this.	it in his country, his virtue is abundant. Who cultivates it in the world, his virtue is universal. Therefore, By one's person one tests persons. By one's house one tests houses. By one's township one tests townships. By one's country one tests countries. By one's world one tests worlds. How do I know that the world is such? Through IT.	it in the world, virtue is universal. Thus, look at self through self; look at the family through the family; look at the village through the village; look at the state through the state; look at the world through the world. How do I know the world? Because it is so.

When man is enriched with Tê, He may be identified with an innocent child. He is free from the stings of insects, Free from the claws of wild beasts, Free from the attacks of devouring birds. None of his bones or muscles are said to be strong, But the grip of his hand is always firm. Nothing concerning the union of male and female is yet known, But potentiality is evident. The essence of	He who embodies abundant virtue May be likened to a ruddy infant: Wasps, venomous insects, scorpions, and snakes Do not sting him; Birds of prey and ferocious beasts Do not seize him. Bones weak, muscles soft, Its grip is firm. Knowing nothing about the copulation Between female and male, Its little penis erects,	One who possesses virtue in abundance is comparable to a new born babe: Poisonous insects will not sting it; Ferocious animals will not pounce on it; Predatory birds will not swoop down on it. Its bones are weak and its sinews supple yet its hold is firm. It does not know the union of male and female yet its male member will stir: This is because its virility is at its height.	The Signet of the Mysterious He who possesses virtue in all its solidity is like unto a little child. Venomous reptiles do not sting him, fierce beasts do not seize him. Birds of prey do not strike him. His bones are weak, his sinews tender, but his grasp is firm. He does not yet know the relation between male and female, but his virility is strong.	One possessing virtue may be compared to an infant. Poisonous insects will not bite, ferocious animals will not pounce, Fetching birds will not prey. Though weak in bones and soft in muscles, his hold is firm; Though ignorant of union, his instrument is turgid. This is supreme
his life is perfect. He can cry all the time without losing his voice. His inner harmony is supreme. To be aware of inner harmony is to abide with reality. To abide with reality is to be enlightened. However, to push life to the full leads to evil. The mind forcing one's potential is artificial. When things are artificial, they lead to decay. This deviates from Tao. That which deviates from Tao ends life soon.	Which manifests sublime virility; It howls all day without becoming hoarse, Which manifests sublime harmony. Knowing harmony means constancy; Knowing constancy means clear-sightedness. Extravagant living means calamity; The heart dominating the breath means collapse. Something ages while still in its prime Is contrary to the Tao.	hoarse: This is because its harmony is at its height. To know harmony is called the constant; To know the constant is called discernment. To try to add to one's vitality is called ill-omened; For the mind to egg on the breath is called violent. A creature in its prime doing harm to the old Is known as going against the way.	Thus his metal grows to perfection. A whole day he might cry and sob without growing hoarse. This shows the perfection of his harmony. To know the harmonious is called the eternal. To know the eternal is called enlightenment. To increase life is called a blessing, and heart-directed vitality is called strength, but things vigorous are about to grow old and I call this un-Reason. Un-Reason soon ceases!	energy. Crying all day without turning hoarse, this is supreme harmony. Knowing harmony is normalcy; knowing normalcy is discernment. Enriching oneself is ominous; overexerting oneself is ruinous. Matter withers after saturation; This is not in line with Direction.

One who is aware does not talk. One who talks is not aware. Ceasing verbal expressions, Stopping the entry of sensations, Dulling its sharpness, Releasing its entanglements, Tempering its brightness, And unifying with the earth: This is called the identity	He who knows does not speak; He who speaks does not know. Stop your hole, Close your door, Soften your brightness, Mingle with the dust, File your sharpness, And unravel your entanglements. This is called deep and remote concord. Therefore, neither	One who knows does not speak; One who speaks does not know. Block the openings; Shut the doors. Blunt the sharpness; Untangle the knots; Soften the glare; Let your wheels move only along old ruts. This is known as mysterious sameness. Hence	The Virtue of the Mysterious One who knows does not talk. One who talks does not know. Therefore the sage keeps his mouth shut and his sense-gates closed. "He will blunt his own sharpness, His own tangles adjust; He will dim his own radiance,	One who knows is reticent; one who glib is ignorant. Stuff channels, block portals; blunt sharpness, resolve conflicts; harmonize brightness, mingle with dust. This is the Profoundest
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of Tao. Hence, no nearness can reach him nor distance affect him. No gain can touch him nor loss disturb him. No esteem can move him nor shame distress him. Thus, he is the most valuable man in the world.	can anyone become intimate with you, Nor can anyone become alienated from you; Neither can anyone benefit you, Nor can anyone harm you; Neither can anyone exalt you, Nor can anyone debase you. Therefore, you are exalted by all under heaven.	you cannot get close to it, nor can you keep it at arm's length; You cannot bestow benefit on it, nor can you do it harm; You cannot ennoble it, nor can you debase it. Therefore it is valued by the empire.	And be one with his dust." This is called profound identification. Thus he is inaccessible to love and also inaccessible to enmity. He is inaccessible to profit and inaccessible to loss. He is also inaccessible to favor and inaccessible to disgrace. Thus he becomes world-honored.	Assimilation. Thus, after gaining possession, one does not patronize, nor slight, nor take advantage of, nor damage, nor treasure, nor debase. Thus, one is treasured by the world.
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Guide the country through tranquillity. Engage in war with rare operations. Win over the world through non-action. How am I aware that this ought to be so? Because of this, the more restrictions and limitations there are, The more impoverished men will be. The more arms men possess, The more disordered the country will be. The more scheming and deceitful men	Use the norm to govern the state; Use the abnormal to conduct warfare; Use nondisturbance to win all under heaven. How do I know it should be so? For the more prohibitions and taboos in the empire, The poorer the people; The more sharp weapons the sovereign has, The more chaotic state and fief; The craftier the sovereign, The more perverse things will arise;	Govern the state by being straightforward; Wage war by being crafty; But win the empire by not being meddlesome. How do I know that it is like that? By means of this. The more taboos there are in the empire The poorer the people; The more sharpened tools the people have The more benighted the state; The more skills the people have The further novelties	Simplicity in Habits With rectitude one governs the state; with craftiness one leads the army; with non-diplomacy one takes the empire. How do I know that it is so? Through IT. The more restrictions and prohibitions are in the empire, the poorer grow the people. The more weapons the people have, the more troubled is the state. The more there is cunning and skill, the more startling events will happen.	Govern a state with orthodoxy; fight a war with heterodoxy; take the world with laissez-faire. How do I know this is so? Because: The world is full of prohibitions, yet the populace is poor; People are stacked with weapons, yet the states are in turmoil; People are loaded with cleverness, yet
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are, The more strange things will occur. The more rules and precepts are enforced, The more bandits and crooks will be produced. Hence, we have the words of the wise: Through my non-action, Men are spontaneously transformed. Through my quiescence, Men spontaneously become tranquil. Through my non-interfering, Men spontaneously increase their wealth. Through my non-willing,	The more ostentatious royal processions, The more robbers and thieves there will be. Hence, the sage man's saying goes: "If I implement nonaction, The people will live and grow spontaneously; If I love stillness, The people will turn aright spontaneously; If I create no disturbances, The people will become rich spontaneously; If I desire to be desireless,	multiply; The better known the laws and edicts The more thieves and robbers there are. Hence the sage says, I take no action and the people are transformed of themselves; I prefer stillness and the people are rectified of themselves; I am not meddlesome and the people prosper of themselves; I am free from desire and the people of themselves become simple like the uncarved block.	The more mandates and laws are enacted, the more there will be thieves and robbers. Therefore the holy man says: I practise non-assertion, and the people of themselves reform. I love quietude, and the people of themselves become righteous. I use no diplomacy, and the people of themselves become rich. I have no desire, and the people of themselves remain simple.	strange schemes sprout; Rules are stringent and well known, yet robbers and thieves abound. Thus, the sage says: Let me practice laissez-faire, and the populace self-develop; Let me seek serenity, and the populace self-manage; Let me be without fanfare, and the populace self-prosper;
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When the country is governed through simplicity and leniency,

The people are genuine and honest.

When the country is governed through harshness and sharp investigation,

The people are more deceitful and dishonest.

From misfortune, good fortune is derived.

In good fortune, misfortune is conceived.

Who can determine the ultimate truth?

If your government is muddled,

Your people will be simple;

If your government is exacting,

Your people will be daring.

Against misfortune leans good fortune;

In good fortune lurks misfortune.

Who knows its extremity?

When the government is muddled

The people are simple;

When the government is alert

The people are cunning.

It is on disaster that good fortune perches;

It is beneath good fortune that disaster crouches.

Who knows the limit? Does not the straightforward exist?

The straightforward changes again into

Adaptation to Change

Whose government is unostentatious, quite unostentatious, his people will be prosperous, quite prosperous. Whose government is prying, quite prying, his people will be needy, quite needy.

Misery, alas! rests upon happiness. Happiness, alas! underlies misery. But who foresees the catastrophe?

When policies are broad, the populace live simply;

When policies are rigid, the populace complain roundly.

Facing disaster, is fortune not in the wing?

Experiencing fortune, is disaster not ready to spring?

Who knows the limit?

There

at all?

As truth often turns out to be untruth,

Goodness often turns out to be evil.

This has long confused the people.

Thus, when the wise deals with things he is firm in his principles,

Yet not sharp.

He is pure, yet not harmful.

He is straightforward, yet not violent.

He is illuminated, yet not glittery.

There is no norm.

Normal reverts to abnormal;

Good reverts to evil.

The perplexity of rulers

Has been long indeed!

Hence, be square without cutting,

Angular without pricking;

Straight without binding;

Bright without dazzling.

the crafty, and the good changes again into the monstrous.

Indeed, it is long since the people were perplexed.

Therefore the sage is square-edged but does not scrape,

Has corners but does not jab,

Extends himself but not at the expense of others,

Shines but does not dazzle.

It will not be prevented!

What is ordinary becomes again extraordinary. What is good becomes again unpropitious. This bewilders people, and it happens constantly since times immemorial.

Therefore the holy man is square but not sharp, strict but not obnoxious, upright but not restraining, bright but not dazzling.

is no norm.

Orthodoxy turns into heterodoxy, good turns into evil.

People have been bewildered long.

Thus,

the sage is square without infringing upon others,

fair without harming others,

straight without imposing upon others,

bright without overshadowing others.

In guiding people and working according to nature, It is best to follow renunciation. Following renunciation means returning soon. Returning soon means accumulating attainment. Accumulating attainment, everything can be dealt with. Dealing with everything leads to limitlessness. With limitlessness, one can	In governing the people and serving heaven, There is nothing like sparingness. Sparingness alone Can lead you to early submission. Early submission means accumulating virtue repeatedly. If you accumulate virtue repeatedly, There is nothing you cannot overcome. If there is nothing you cannot overcome, Nobody knows	In ruling the people and in serving heaven it is best for a ruler to be sparing. It is because he is sparing That he may be said to follow the way from the start; Following the way from the start he may be said to accumulate an abundance of virtue; Accumulating an abundance of virtue there is	Hold Fast to Reason To govern the people is the affair of heaven and there is nothing like thrift. Now consider that thrift is said to come from early practice. By early practice it is said that we can accumulate an abundance of virtue. If one accumulates an abundance of virtue then there is nothing that can not be overcome.	In governing people and in taking care of the cosmos, the best is restraint. With restraint, one is ever ready. Ever ready, one focuses on virtue. Focusing on virtue, one overcomes everything. Overcoming everything, one's limit does not
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govern the country. Governing the country through its origin leads to endurance. This means that to root deeply and to plant firmly leads to longevity and eternal consciousness. Therefore, governing a large nation is as simple as preparing a dish of food.	its limit. If nobody knows its limit, You are fit to possess a state. If you possess the mother of governing a state, You may long endure. This is called the way To deepen the roots and strengthen the base, To lengthen life and perpetuate vision.	nothing he cannot overcome; When there is nothing he cannot overcome, no one knows his limit; When no one knows his limit He can possess a state; When he possesses the mother of a state He can then endure. This is called the way of deep roots and firm stems by which one lives to see many days.	When nothing can not be overcome then no one knows his limit. When no one knows his limit one can have possession of the commonwealth. Who has possession of the commonwealth's mother [thrift] may last and abide. This is called the possession of deep roots and of a staunch stem. To life, to everlastingness, to comprehension, this is the way.	come into being. With one's limit not coming into being, one gains the state. Having the foundation to governance, one lasts long. This is deep root and solid foundation. This is Direction - long lasting and long living.
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When Tao prevails in the world, evil loses its power.

It is not that evil no longer possesses spiritual power.

It is that its power does not damage men.

Indeed, it is not

Governing a large state

Is like frying small fish.

Use the Tao to preside over the empire,

And its spirits will not be mischievous;

Not that its spirits will not be mischievous,

But

Governing a large state is like boiling a small fish.

When the empire is ruled in accordance with the way,

The spirits lose their potencies.

Or rather, it is not that they lose their potencies,

But that, though they have their

How to Maintain One's Place

Govern a great country as you would fry small fish: [neither gut nor scale them.]

If with Reason the empire is managed, its ghosts will not spook.

Govern a large state is like frying a small fish.

With Direction embracing the world, ghosts become ineffective.

It is not because ghosts become ineffective;

it is because

that its power does not damage men.

It is primarily that the ruler does not become harmful to men.

When opposites no longer damage each other,

Both are benefitted through the attainment of Tao.

that their mischief will not harm the people;

Not that their mischief will not harm the people,

But that a sage man never does any harm.

Since neither harms anyone,

Their favors will converge.

potencies, they do not harm the people.

It is not only they who, having their potencies, do not harm the people,

The sage, also, does not harm the people.

As neither does any harm, each attributes the merit to the other.

Not only will its ghosts not spook, but its gods will not harm the people. Not only will its gods not harm the people, but neither will its holy men harm the people. Since neither will do harm, therefore their virtues will be combined.

their effect becomes inoffensive.

Not only have ghosts become inoffensive;

The sage has also become inoffensive.

With the two not inflicting harm, the people are showered with virtue.

A greater nation must be humble and like a reservoir

Where all the waters join together.

It is the passivity of the universe.

Passivity always prevails over activity through quiescence.

Quiescence is humble before activity.

When a greater nation is humble before a lesser nation,

It prevails over the lesser nation.

When a lesser nation is humble before a greater nation,

It prevails

A large state is the lower stream,

The female to all under heaven,

The converging point of all under heaven.

The female constantly uses stillness

To overcome the male.

As she is still,

It is proper that she stay low.

Therefore, if a large state

Stays low to a small state,

It wins the small state;

A large state is the lower reaches of a river:

The place where all the streams of the world unite.

In the union of the world,

The female always gets the better of the male by stillness.

Being still, she takes the lower position.

Hence the large state, by taking the lower position, annexes the small state;

The small state, by taking the lower position, affiliates itself to the large

The Virtue of Humility

A great state, one that lowly flows, becomes the empire's union, and the empire's wife.

The wife always through quietude conquers her husband, and by quietude renders herself lowly.

Thus a great state through lowliness toward small states will conquer the small states, and small states through lowliness toward great states will conquer great

A great nation is like a down-stream - the feminine to the world, the rendezvous of the world.

The feminine frequently wins over the masculine with serenity.

Serenity is obsequiousness.

Thus,

a great nation, obsequious to a small nation, gains the small nation;

a small nation, obsequious to a great nation, gains the great nation.

over the greater nation.

Thus, by being humble one prevails over others.

Or, by being originally in a lower position,

One prevails over others.

A greater nation simply likes to bring people together

And to nurture them.

A lesser nation simply likes to participate

And work together with others.

In this way, both have what they like,

Stays low to a large state,

It is won by the large state.

Therefore, one stays low to win;

One stays low to be won.

Therefore, the large state

Merely wishes to annex and feed the other;

The small state

Merely wishes to join and serve the other.

If each is to have its wish,

The large state should stay lower.

state.

Thus the one, by taking the lower position, annexes;

The other, by taking the lower position, is annexed.

All that the large state wants is to take the other under its wing;

All that the small state wants is to have its services accepted by the other.

If each of the two wants to find its proper place,

It is meet that the large should take the lower position.

states.

Therefore some render themselves lowly for the purpose of conquering; others are lowly and therefore conquer.

A great state desires no more than to unite and feed the people; a small state desires no more than to devote itself to the service of the people; but that both may obtain their wishes, the greater one must stoop.

Thus, one is obsequious in order to gain.

Or, one is obsequious because it needs to gain.

A great nation is not to be too keen on conquering.

A small nation is not to be too keen on acquiescing.

Since each gains what each desires, it is better for the great nation to be obsequious.

Tao is concealed in the depths of all things. The worthy value it. The unworthy are protected by it. Good words may be traded for honor. Good works may impress men. Even if a man is unworthy, Tao will never exclude him. Although in a great nation an emperor is established, Ministers are appointed, and Jade	The Tao is where The ten thousand things flow; The good man's treasure, That by which the evil man is preserved. Good words can win one honor; Good deeds can command esteem from others. The evil among men - Why should they be abandoned? Therefore, in enthroning the Son of Heaven, Or installing the Three Counselors,	The way is the refuge for the myriad creatures. It is that by which the good man protects, And that by which the bad is protected. Beautiful words when offered will win high rank in return; Beautiful deeds can raise a man above others. Even if a man is not good, why should he be abandoned? Hence when the emperor is set up and the three ducal	Practise Reason The man of Reason is the ten thousand creatures' refuge, the good man's wealth, the bad man's stay. With beautiful words one can sell. With honest conduct one can do still more with the people. If a man be bad, why should he be thrown away?	Direction, to myriad matters, is an enclosure; to people who are good, it is a treasure; to people who are not good, it can reassure. Good words gain people's respect; good deeds gain people's admiration. Why abandon people who are not good? Thus, when a King is enthroned, three senior
and horses are all decorated, None of these is a better offer to the nation than Tao. Tao has been highly esteemed since the remote past. Why? Because not searching for it, one obtains it. Even if one has faults, one is free from them. Thus, the Tao is the most highly esteemed thing in the universe.	has a jade-disk That fills one's arms, Preceding a team of four horses, It is better to prostrate oneself And present this. Why did the ancients treasure this Tao so? Is it not said: "What one seeks will thereby be obtained; What one is guilty of will thereby be pardoned?" Therefore it was treasured by all under heaven.	ministers are appointed, he who makes a present of the way without stirring from his seat is preferable to one who offers presents of jade disks followed by a team of four horses. Why was this way valued of old? Was it not said that by means of it one got what one wanted and escaped the consequences when one transgressed? Therefore it is valued by the empire.	Therefore, an emperor was elected and three ministers appointed; but better than holding before one's face the jade table [of the ministry] and riding with four horses, is sitting still and propounding the eternal Reason. Why do the ancients prize this Reason? Is it not, say, because when sought it is obtained and the sinner thereby can be saved? Therefore it is world-honored.	positions are filled. Though there are precious jades and speedy stallions, the best present is Direction. Why, through the ages, is Direction so valued? Is it not because whoever seeks it gets it, and whoever is guilty, with it, receives amnesty? That is why it is so valued by the world.

Action or non-action, work or non-work, knowledge or non-knowledge, Large or small, more or less: It is just like returning hatred with love, Contemplating the difficult with the easy, Working on the great through the small. Because the hard tasks in the world must be preceded by what is easy, Great affairs in the world must	Act without action; Disturb without disturbance; Taste the tasteless. Great, small, much, little, Requite enmity with favor. Tackle a difficult issue while it is easy; Create a great enterprise while it is small. All difficult issues under heaven Begin from easy ones; All great enterprises under heaven	Do that which consists in taking no action; Pursue that which is not meddlesome; Savor that which has no flavor. Make the small big and the few many; Do good to him who has done you an injury. Lay plans for the accomplishment of the difficult before it becomes difficult; Make something big by starting with it when small. Difficult things in the world must needs have their beginnings in the easy;	Consider Beginnings Assert non-assertion. Practise non-practice. Taste the tasteless. Make great the small. Make much the little. Requite hatred with virtue. Contemplate a difficulty when it is easy. Manage a great thing when it is small. The world's most difficult undertakings necessarily originate while easy, and the world's greatest undertakings necessarily originate	Govern with laissez-faire. Act without fanfare. Dine with the commonest fare. Big begins as small; many accrue from few. In tackling difficult tasks, first tackle those easy; In tackling big tasks, first tackle those flimsy. The difficult tasks of the world begin as easy; The big
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begin with what is minute. Hence, the wise never works on what is great; He achieves what is great. The easier it is to promise a thing, The less one can fulfill. The more lightly things are taken, The more difficulties occur. Therefore, the wise takes things as difficult; He is always free from the difficult.	small ones. Hence, the sage man never presumed vastness, So, he could achieve vastness. For he who makes promises lightly Must lack in trustworthiness; He who takes many things easy Must encounter many difficulties. Hence, even the sage man Considered the task difficult, Therefore, eventually he had no difficulty.	Big things must needs have their beginnings in the small. Therefore it is because the sage never attempts to be great that he succeeds in becoming great. One who makes promises rashly rarely keeps good faith; One who is in the habit of considering things easy meets with frequent difficulties. Therefore even the sage treats some things as difficult. That is why in the end no difficulties can get the better of him.	while small. Therefore the holy man to the end does not venture to play the great, and thus he can accomplish his greatness. Rash promises surely lack faith, and many easy things surely involve in many difficulties. Therefore, the holy man regards everything as difficult, and thus to the end encounters no difficulties.	tasks of the world begin as flimsy. Thus, the sage, who never considers self big, completes many big tasks. Thus, promise easily made leads to promise not fulfilled; difficulty underestimated leads to difficulty multiplied. Thus, the sage, in treating every task as difficult, encounters no difficulties.
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That which is motionless is easy to maintain.	When stable,	It is easy to maintain a situation while it is still secure;	Mind the Insignificant	Governing is easy when there is peace;
That which is prior to emergence is easy to deal with.	It is easy to maintain;	It is easy to deal with a situation before symptoms develop;	What is still at rest is easily kept quiet. What has not as yet appeared is easily prevented.	Planning is easy when there is time;
That which is just beginning is easy to destroy.	When no symptoms have emerged,	It is easy to break a thing when it is yet brittle;	What is still feeble is easily broken. What is still scant is easily dispersed.	Nipping is easy when buds are young;
That which is minute is easy to disperse.	Easy to deal with;	It is easy to dissolve a thing when it is yet minute.		Reconciling is easy when issues are minor.
Act on what is before it occurs.	When tender,	Deal with a thing while it is still nothing;	Treat things before they exist. Regulate things before disorder begins.	Handle matters before they come about;
Manage things before they are in disorder.	Easy to break;	Keep a thing in order before disorder sets in.	The stout tree has originated from a tiny rootlet. A tower of nine stories is raised by heaping up [bricks of] clay. A thousand miles' journey begins with a foot.	Govern people before there is chaos.
Big trees grow out of small shoots.	When tiny,	A tree that can fill the span of a man's arms		A tree two-arms'-length wide grows from a seedling;
A nine story tower begins to be built from one little lump.	Easy to disperse.	Grows from a downy tip;		A tower nine stories high starts with a spadeful;
A journey of a thousand miles begins from where one stays.	Tackle it before it takes shape;	A terrace nine storeys high	He that makes mars. He that grasps loses.	A journey a thousand miles long begins with a step.
Those who proceed through action fail.	Bring order before it becomes chaotic.	Rises from hodfuls of earth;		The
	A tree the circumference of an embrace	A journey of a thousand miles		
	Grows out of a downy tip;	Starts from beneath one's feet.		
	A nine-storied tower	Whoever does anything to it will ruin		
	Rises from a basketful of earth;			
	A hundred-ren ascent			
	Begins from under one's foot.			
	He who acts upon them ruins them;			

the wise does not act on things and is free from failure.	—	it;	He does not grasp; therefore he loses not. The people when undertaking an enterprise are always near completion, and yet they fail.	populace often fail when they are close to completing their tasks.
He does not grasp on to things, and does not lose them.	—	Whoever lays hold of it will lose it.		Be as deliberate at the end as at the beginning; then, there can be no failure.
People who are engaged with things often fail when they almost complete them.	—	Therefore the sage, because he does nothing, never ruins anything;	Remain careful to the end as in the beginning and you will not fail in your enterprise.	Thus, the sage desires what others do not desire, and places no premium on rare goods.
Therefore, one should be as careful in the last stage of one's work as at the beginning.	—	And, because he does not lay hold of anything, loses nothing.	Therefore the holy man desires to be desireless, and does not prize articles difficult to obtain. He learns, not to be learned, and seeks a home where multitudes of people pass by.	[The sage] studies what others do not study, and revisits people's faults.
Then one will be free from failure.	—	In their enterprises the people	He assists the ten thousand things in their natural development, but he does not venture to interfere.	
Hence, for the wise, willing is non-willing.	—	Always ruin them when on the verge of success.		
He never values things which are hard to attain.	—	Be as careful at the end as at the beginning		
He learns what is unlearned.	—	And there will be no ruined enterprises.		
He avoids the mistakes that have been made by others.	—	Therefore the sage desires not to desire		
	—	And does not value goods which are hard to come by;		
	—	Learns to be without learning		
	—	And makes good the mistakes of the multitude		
	—	In order to help the myriad creatures to be natural and to refrain from daring to act.		
	—			

In the remote past, the man who was good in Tao did not lead his people to calculative thinking, But let them remain ignorant of it. The difficulty in cultivating men is that they are full of intellectual discrimination. Governing the nation through intellectual discrimination is harmful to it. Not	Therefore, it is said: "Those who implemented the Tao Did not use it to make the people shrewd; Rather, they used it to make them simple." The reason why the people are difficult to rule Is that they are crafty. Therefore, using craft to govern a state Is a pest to the sta — t —	Of old those who excelled in the pursuit of the way did not use it to enlighten the people but to hoodwink them. The reason why the people are difficult to govern is that they are too clever. Hence to rule a state by cleverness Will be to the detriment of	The Virtue of Simplicity The ancients who were well versed in Reason did not thereby enlighten the people; they intended thereby to make them simple-hearted. If people are difficult to govern, it is because they are too smart. To govern the country with smartness is the country's curse.	Men who knew Direction in olden days did not teach the populace to be clever, but teach them to be simple. A populace that is clever is difficult to govern. Thus, governing with cleverness robs a state; governing not with
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governing the nation through intellectual discrimination is a blessing to it. Knowing the difference between these two sets a standard. To be aware of this standard is profound attainment. Profound attainment is deep and far-reaching. It is the reversal of ordinary things, yet it leads to great harmony with Tao.	Using noncraft to govern a state Is a blessing to the state. Constantly remember: these two constitute a guideline; Constantly remembering this guideline Is called a deep and remote virtue. The deep and remote virtue Is deep indeed, remote indeed; And, though contrary to all things,	the state; Not to rule a state by cleverness Will be a boon to the state. These two are models. Always to know the models Is known as mysterious virtue. Mysterious virtue is profound and far-reaching, But when things turn back it turns back with them. Only then is complete conformity realized.	To govern the country without smartness is the country's blessing. He who knows these two things is also a model [like the ancients]. Always to know the model is called profound virtue. Spiritual virtue, verily, is profound. Verily, it is far-reaching. Verily, it is to everything reverse. But then it will procure great recognition.	cleverness benefits a state. One who knows [the difference between] these two sets the standard. Knowing the standard at all times is Profoundest Virtue. Profoundest Virtue is deep; it is far. Profoundest Virtue returns matters to naturalness, to the Grand Gentleness.
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Rivers and seas
become the leading
powers over all the
waters from the
highlands

Because they place
themselves in low
positions before the
other waters.

That is why rivers
and seas become the
leading powers over
all the waters from
the highlands.

Thus, when the ruler
wishes to become the
leader of his people,
He first humbles
himself before them.

When he wishes to
be in

The reason why rivers
and oceans

Can become kings of
a hundred valley
streams

Is that they are good at
lying below them;

Hence, they can
become

Kings of a hundred
valley streams.

Hence, when the sage
man

Wished to be above
the people,

He always placed
himself below them in
speech;

When he wished to be
in

The reason why the
River and the Sea are
able to be king of the
hundred valleys is
that they excel in
taking the lower
position.

Hence they are able
to be king of the
hundred valleys.

Therefore, desiring to
rule over the people,

One must in one's
words humble
oneself before them;

And, desiring to lead
the people,

One must, in one's

Putting Oneself
Behind

That rivers and
oceans can of the
hundred valleys be
kings is due to their
excelling in
lowliness. Thus they
can of the hundred
valleys be the kings.

Therefore the holy
man, when anxious
to be above the
people, must in his
words keep
underneath them.

The sea is the king to
hundreds of streams.

Because it is good at
lying low, it can be
the king to hundreds
of streams.

Thus, a sage,

desirous of being the
populace's superior,
must be obsequious
to them;

desirous of being in
front of the populace,
must follow them.

Thus,

front of his people,
He first remains in
back of them.

When he is in a high
position, people do
not feel his authority.

When he is in front
of his people, they do
not feel any
obstruction.

Therefore, all the
people want to
support him, and no
one dislikes him.

It is because he never
contends with others
that others are unable
to quarrel with him.

front of the people,

He always stayed
behind them in
person.

Therefore, when he
was above,

People did not
consider him a
burden;

When he was in front,

People did not
consider him an
obstacle.

All under heaven
delighted in
supporting him
unwearily.

Is it not because he
did not contend

person, follow
behind them.

Therefore the sage
takes his place over
the people yet is no
burden;

takes his place ahead
of the people yet
causes no
obstruction.

That is why the
empire supports him
joyfully and never
tires of doing so.

It is because he does
not contend that no
one in the empire is
in a position to
contend with him.

When anxious to lead
the people, he must
with his person keep
behind them.

Therefore the holy
man dwells above,
but the people are not
burdened. He is
ahead, but the people
suffer no harm.

Therefore the world
rejoices in exalting
him and does not tire.
Because he strives
not, no one in the
world will strive with
him.

a sage,

sitting high, in no
way burdens the
populace;

standing in front, in
no way harms the
populace.

Thus, the world is
happy to support [the
sage] and is not tired
of doing so.

Because [the sage] is
not in competition,
the people in the
world cannot engage
him/her in
competition.

The world says that I am beyond determination

And cannot be identified with anything.

It is because I am beyond determination that I cannot be identified with anything.

If I could be identified with anything,

I would no longer be beyond determination.

There are three essentials that I value and maintain:

One is compassion (tz'u),

Another is renunciation (ch'ien),

The third is never longing to be first in the world.

One who is compassionate is able to be valiant.

One who renounces is able to broaden one's self.

One who never longs to be

All under heaven say I am vast;

Vast, but resemble nothing.

It is precisely because I resemble nothing

That I can be vast.

If I had resembled anything,

Long ago I would have become tiny indeed.

I constantly have three treasures

Which I uphold and value:

First, compassion;

Second, frugality;

Third, not daring to precede all under heaven.

Being compassionate,

I can be courageous;

Being frugal,

I can be all-embracing;

Not daring to

The whole world says that my way is vast and resembles nothing.

It is because it is vast that it resembles nothing.

If it resembled anything, it would, long before now, have become small.

I have three treasures

Which I hold and cherish.

The first is known as compassion,

The second is known as frugality,

The third is known as not daring to take the lead in the empire;

The Three Treasures

All in the world call me great; but I resemble the unlikely. Now a man is great only because he resembles the unlikely. Did he resemble the likely, how lasting, indeed, would his mediocrity be!

1 have three treasures which I cherish and prize. The first is called compassion. The second is called economy. The third is called not daring to come to the front in the world.

The compassionate

People in the world say that my Direction is grand as if without a referent.

It is because it is grand that Direction is without a referent.

Were it capable of being referenced, it would not be grand.

I have three treasures - embrace and safeguard them.

One, affection.

Two, restraint.

Three, daring not to be at the front of [the people] of

first in the world

Is able to achieve the full growth of his capacity.

In the present day, people wish to be valiant,

But they are not compassionate.

They wish to broaden their selves,

But they do not renounce.

They wish to achieve the full growth of their capacities,

But they long to be first in the world.

This indeed leads to death.

Through compassion, engaging in war, one wins.

In self-defense, one is very well protected.

This type of person is saved by heaven.

precede all under heaven,

I can serve as

Head of the great vessels.

Now, if I had abandoned compassion and chosen courage,

Abandoned frugality and chosen all-embracingness;

Abandoned the back and chosen the front,

It would have been the death of me.

For compassion, used in battle,

Will bring you victory;

Used in defence,

Will make you impregnable.

When heaven is about to establish someone,

It seems to wall him up with compassion.

be courageous,

Being frugal one could afford to extend one's territory,

Not daring to take the lead in the empire one could afford to be lord over the vessels.

Now, to forsake compassion for courage, to forsake frugality for expansion, to forsake the rear for the lead, is sure to end in death.

Through compassion, one will triumph in attack and be impregnable in defence.

What heaven succours it protects with the gift of compassion.

can be brave; the economical can be generous; those who dare not come to the front in the world can become perfect as chief vessels.

Now, if people discard compassion and are brave; if they discard economy and are generous; if they discard modesty and are ambitious, they will surely die.

the world.

With affection, one becomes courageous;

With restraint, one becomes tolerant;

Daring not to be at the front of the world, one is at the head.

One courts death if one forsakes affection for courage,

forsakes restraint for tolerance,

forsakes humility for prominence.

With affection,

in war, one wins;

in defense, strengthens.

When cosmos comes to the rescue, it shields with affection.

A good soldier is free from violence. A good fighter is free from rage. A good winner is free from competition. A good leader is humble before the	Therefore, a good commander is not militant; A good strategist is not irritable; A good vanquisher of enemies is not confrontational; A good employer of men stays low	One who excels as a warrior does not appear formidable; One who excels in fighting is never roused in anger; One who excels in defeating his enemy does not join issue; One who excels	Complying With Heaven He who excels as a warrior is not warlike. He who excels as a fighter is not wrathful. He who excels in conquering the enemy does not strive.	One good at commandership does not easily use force, one good at war is not easily provoked, one good at winning does not easily engage in
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people. This is called the attainment of non-contention, Or the application of the strength of others. It is also called identity with the ultimate Beyond space and time.	to them. This is called the virtue of noncontention; This is called the ability of employing men; This is called a match for heaven, A paragon among the ancients.	in employing others humbles himself before them. This is known as the virtue of non-contention; This is known as making use of the efforts of others; This is known as matching the sublimity of heaven.	He who excels in employing men is lowly. This is called the virtue of not-striving. This is called utilizing men's ability. This is called complying with heaven-since olden times the highest.	combat, one good at deployment is obsequious. This is the virtue of non-engagement; this is the ability at deployment. This is fully consistent with the cosmos.
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On military operations we have: "I do not boldly attack others first, But take action only after being attacked." "I do not boldly move forward even an inch, But withdraw a foot." This is called the operation of non-operation, Bearing the arms of non-arms, Charging the enemy of non-enemy, Carrying the	A strategist once said: "I dare not play the host, Rather, I'd play the guest; I dare not advance one inch, Rather, I'd retreat one foot. Which means: Marching without ranks, Baring no arms,	The strategists have a saying, I dare not play the host but play the guest, I dare not advance an inch but retreat a foot instead. This is known as marching forward when there is no road, Rolling up one's sleeves when there is no arm, Dragging one's adversary by force	The Function of the Mysterious A military expert used to say: 'I dare not act as host [who takes the initiative] but act as guest [with reserve]. I dare not advance an inch, but I withdraw a foot.' This is called marching without marching, threatening without arms, charging	A saying among warriors: I dare not play host, I prefer playing guest; I dare not advance an inch, I prefer retreating a foot. This is formless formation, this is defenseless advancement, this is oppositionless
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weapons of non-weapons. There is no more serious misfortune Than to engage in war lightly. To engage in war lightly is to violate my essential teachings of compassion, renunciation, and never longing to be first in the world. Therefore, when two armies join in battle, The one that is compassionate wins.	Holding no weapons, I will still emerge invincible. No calamity is greater than being invincible; Being invincible almost cost me my treasures." Therefore, when two confronting armies are equally matched, The compassionate party wins.	when there is no adversary, And taking up arms when there are no arms. There is no disaster greater than taking on an enemy too easily. So doing nearly cost me my treasure. Thus of two sides raising arms against each other, It is the one that is sorrow-stricken that wins.	without hostility, seizing without weapons. No greater misfortune than making light of the enemy! When we make light of the enemy, it is almost as though we had lost our treasure--[compassion]. Thus, if matched armies encounter one another, the one who does so in sorrow is sure to conquer.	encounter, this is weaponless display. No disaster is greater than underestimating the enemy. Underestimating the enemy verges on losing my treasures. Thus, when two equal-size armies are in combat, the one that is grieved wins.
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It is not difficult to grasp my words or to follow them.

Yet no one in the world can grasp them or follow them.

Because words must derive from the source of words,

Action requires an

My words are exceedingly easy to understand,

Exceedingly easy to practice.

Yet none under heaven can understand them,

None can practice them.

Words have their progenitor;

Affairs have their sovereign.

It is because of

My words are very easy to understand and very easy to put into practice,

Yet no one in the world can understand them or put them into practice.

Words have an ancestor and affairs have a sovereign.

It

Difficult to Understand

My words are very easy to understand and very easy to practise, but in the world no one can understand, no one can practise them.

Words have an ancestor; Deeds have a master [viz., Reason].

My words are easy to understand and easy to put into practice.

But no one in the world understands [my words], and no one puts them into practice.

Words must be principled; actions

actor who acts.

Since you are not aware of this, you cannot know me.

The less people know me, the more valuable I am.

Thus, the wise is covered with tattered clothes which conceal precious jade.

ignorance

That they do not me understand.

Those who understand being rare,

I become all the more valuable.

Hence, the sage man wore a coarse tunic,

But carried in his bosom a piece of jade.

is because people are ignorant that they fail to understand me.

Those who understand me are few;

Those who harm me are honoured.

Therefore the sage, while clad in homespun, conceals on his person a priceless piece of jade.

Since he is not understood, therefore I am not understood.

Those who understand me are few, and thus I am distinguished.

Therefore the holy man wears wool, and hides in his bosom his jewels.

must be justified.

Because these are not understood, I am not understood.

With few who understand me, fewer will put [my words] into practice.

Thus, a sage dresses simply but bears a jade.

Knowing that which cannot be known is perfect.

Not being aware of this knowing is a defect.

To be aware of defects as defects

Knowing as if not knowing

Is peerless;

Not knowing as if knowing

Is a sickness.

Hence,

To know yet to think that one does not know is best;

Not to know yet to think that one knows will lead to difficulty.

It is by

The Disease of Knowledge

To know the unknowable, that is elevating. Not to know the knowable, that is sickness.

Only by becoming sick

Knowing that one does not know is best;

Not knowing but pretending to know is a fault.

A sage has no faults, because he/she

is to be free from defects.

The wise is free from defects.

He is aware of defects as defects.

Therefore, he is free from defects.

the sage man was not sick:

Being sick of the sickness,

Hence, he was not sick.

being alive to difficulty that one can avoid it.

The sage meets with no difficulty.

It is because he is alive to it that he meets with no difficulty.

of sickness can we be without sickness.

The holy man is not sick. Because he is sick of sickness, therefore he is not sick.

is aware of his/her faults and works on these faults.

Because a sage is aware of faults and works on them, he/she has no faults.

When people are free from fear,
They experience "basic dread."
Because they are not limited by the places in which they stay,
They are at peace with their lives.
Because they are at peace with

If the people do not fear terror,
Greater terror shall arrive.
Do not squeeze their habitation;
Do not obstruct their livelihood.
Only when you stop oppressing

When the people lack a proper sense of awe, then some awful visitation will descend upon them.
Do not constrict their living space;
Do not press down on their means of livelihood.
It is because you do not

Holding Oneself Dear
If the people do not fear the dreadful, the great dreadful will come, surely.
Let them not deem their lives narrow.
Let them not deem their lot wearisome.

When the populace is unafraid of threats, major threats loom.
Do not harass their neighborhood;
Do not interfere with their livelihood.
Thus, without interference,

their lives,
Their lives are peaceful.
Therefore, the wise is aware of himself,
But does not display himself.
He cultivates himself,
But is not proud of himself.
He leaves behind small fear,
But experiences basic dread.

them
Will they stop loathing you.
Hence, the sage man
Knew himself without parading himself,
Loved himself without exalting himself.
Therefore, he abandoned that and chose this.

press down on them that they will not weary of the burden.
Hence the sage knows himself but does not display himself,
Loves himself but does not exalt himself.
Therefore he discards the one and takes the other.

When it is not deemed wearisome, then it will not be wearisome.
Therefore the holy man knows himself but does not display himself. He holds himself dear but does not honor himself.
Thus he discards the latter and chooses the former.

people will not interfere.
Thus, the sage knows self without self-touting, respects self without self-aggrandizement.
Thus,
forsake self-touting and self-aggrandizement;
embrace self-knowledge and self-respect.

Courageous but foolhardy, one perishes. Courageous but not foolhardy, one's life is saved. Between these two, one gains, the other loses. Who knows what nature loathes? Even the sage can hardly make a wise choice. According to the way	Brave in daring, one gets killed; Brave in not daring, one lives. Of these two - One is beneficial, one harmful. That which heaven loathes - Who knows its reason?	He who is fearless in being bold will meet with his death; He who is fearless in being timid will stay alive. Of the two, one leads to good, the other to harm. Heaven hates what it hates, Who knows the reason why? Therefore even the sage treats some things as	Daring to Act Courage, if carried to daring, leads to death; courage, if not carried to daring, leads to life. Either of these two things is sometimes beneficial, sometimes harmful. "Why 't is by heaven rejected, Who has the reason detected?" Therefore the holy man also regards it as difficult.	Courageous in accepting dare results in demise; courageous in declining dare results in survival. Between these two, there are advantages and disadvantages. The cosmos has dislikes, but no one knows the reason. It is hard even for the sage to explain. The Direction of the
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of heaven, Without contending, one inevitably wins. Without asking, one spontaneously receives a response. Without invitation, success comes by itself. Unintentionally, the heavenly way is well-devised. The net of nature is all-embracing. Although the spaces are large, nothing escapes it.	Heaven's Tao, Without battling, excels in triumphing; Without speaking, excels in responding; Without being summoned, comes spontaneously; Though loose, excels in planning. Heaven's net is vast: Though wide-meshed, misses nothing.	difficult. The way of heaven Excels in overcoming though it does not contend, In responding though it does not speak, In attracting though it does not summon, In laying plans though it appears slack. The net of heaven is cast wide. Though the mesh is not fine, yet nothing ever slips through.	The Heavenly Reason strives not, but it is sure to conquer. It speaks not, but it is sure to respond. It summons not, but it comes of itself. It works patiently, but is sure in its designs. Heaven's net is vast, so vast. It is wide-meshed, but it loses nothing.	cosmos, though does not compete, is good at winning; though wordless, is good at responding; needs no invitation and comes on own volition; and is at ease and is good at planning. The cosmos's net is immense; it is loose but it does not miss.
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Men are no longer afraid to die.

Why should we frighten them with dying?

If men were still as afraid of death as they used to be,

We could catch a criminal and put him to death.

Who would have the courage to commit a crime?

(In nature), there is

If the majority of people do not fear death,

Why use killing to intimidate them?

If the majority of people do fear death,

Those who act perversely -

I can arrest and kill them.

Who would dare then?

The Executioner is

When the people are not afraid of death, wherefore frighten them with death?

Were the people always afraid of death, and were I able to arrest and put to death those who innovate, then who would dare?

There is a regular executioner whose

Overcome Delusion

If the people do not fear death, how can they be frightened by death? If we make people fear death, and supposing some would [still] venture to rebel, if we seize them for capital punishment, who will dare?

There is always an executioner who kills.

When the populace are unafraid of death, what good is threatening them with death?

When the populace are afraid to die, hold devious ones and put them to death.

After that, who dares?

The

always one who is responsible for ending the life of man.

If we take over the responsibility of killing,

It is just like taking over the great lumberjack's work of cutting wood.

If we take over the great lumberjack's work of cutting,

We can hardly help but hurt our hands.

always the one in charge of killing;

To kill in place of the Executioner

Is to chop wood in place of a master carpenter.

To chop wood in place of a master carpenter,

One can hardly avoid injuring one's own hand.

charge it is to kill.

To kill on behalf of the executioner is what is described as chopping wood on behalf of the master carpenter.

In chopping wood on behalf of the master carpenter, there are few who escape hurting their own hands instead.

Now to take the place of the executioner who kills is taking the place of the great carpenter who hews. If a man takes the place of the great carpenter who hews, he will rarely, indeed, fail to injure his hand.

official executioner is always there to do executions.

Doing executions by anyone else is like felling trees by other than an arborist.

A non-arborist, in felling trees, is unlikely not to hurt his hands.

When men are deprived of food, It is because their kings tax them too heavily. Therefore, they are deprived of food. When men are hard to govern, It is because their kings interfere with their lives. Therefore, they are hard	The people are starving, Because he takes too much grain tax, Hence, they are starving. The hundred family names are unruly, Because their sovereign has the intention to act, Hence, they are	The people are hungry: It is because those in authority eat up too much in taxes That the people are hungry. The people are difficult to govern. It is because those in authority are too fond of action That the people are difficult	Harmed Through Greed The people hunger because their superiors consume too many taxes; therefore they hunger. The people are difficult to govern because their superiors are too meddlesome; therefore they are difficult to govern.	Starvation in the populace is caused by excessive taxes. Excessive taxes result in starvation. Difficulty in governing the populace is caused by a governor's interferences. Interferences result in difficulties in governance. Indifference to
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to govern. When men give up their lives lightly, It is because their kings are anxious to live extravagantly. Therefore, men give up their lives lightly. Only one who disregards his own life Knows how to value the lives of others.	unruly. The people take death lightly, Because he seeks after extravagant living, Hence, they take death lightly. Only one who does not apply himself to living Is worthier than those who exalt living.	to govern. The people treat death lightly: It is because the people set too much store by life That they treat death lightly. It is just because one has no use for life that one is wiser than the man who values life.	The people make light of death on account of the intensity of their clinging to life; therefore they make light of death. He who is not bent on life is worthier than he who esteems life.	death in the populace is caused by a governor's overindulgence. A governor's overindulgence results in the populace's indifference to death. One who does not overindulgence is wiser than one who overvalues one's life.
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When a man is alive,
His body is soft and frail.
After his death,
It is hard and solid.
When grass and trees are growing,
They are delicate and fragile.
After their deaths,
They are wizened and decayed.
Therefore, what is hard is

When born, man is soft and weak;
When dead, he is stiff, tough, hard and strong.
When born, the ten thousand things,
Grasses and trees are soft and tender;
When dead, they are withered and dry.
Therefore, it is said:
"The hard and strong

A man is supple and weak when living, but hard and stiff when dead.
Grass and trees are pliant and fragile when living, but dried and shrivelled when dead.
Thus the hard and the strong are the comrades of death;
The supple

Beware of Strength
Man during life is tender and delicate.
When he dies he is stiff and stark.
The ten thousand things, the grass as well as the trees, while they live are tender and supple.
When they die they are rigid and dry.
Thus the hard and the strong are the companions of death.

At birth, one is soft and tender;
at death, hard and stiff.
At the beginning, flora are tender and crisp;
at the end, brittle and dry.
Thus, hardness and stiffness

close to death.
What is soft is close to life.
Thus, when troops are inflexible, they lose the war.
When a wood board is dried hard, it cracks.
What is strongest and most solid remains low.
What is softest and meekest remains high.

belong to the category of death;
The soft and weak belong to the category of life."
Hence, if an army is strong, it perishes;
If a tree is strong, it breaks.
Therefore, the strong and big rank low;
The soft and weak rank high.

and the weak are the comrades of life.
Therefore a weapon that is strong will not vanquish;
A tree that is strong will suffer the axe.
The strong and big takes the lower position,
The supple and weak takes the higher position.

The tender and the delicate are the companions of life.
Therefore he who in arms is strong will not conquer.
When a tree has grown strong it is doomed.
The strong and the great stay below. The tender and the delicate stay above.

symbolize death; softness and tenderness, life.
Thus, an army, hard and stiff, is annihilated; a tree, hard and stiff, is cut.
Hard and stiff are inferior; soft and tender, superior.

The course of nature is similar to the curve of a bow: That which is at the top is pulled down; That which is at the bottom is brought up. That which is overfull is reduced; That which is deficient is supplemented. The course of nature is to reduce what is overfull And to supplement what is deficient. The course of man	Heaven's Tao Is like the fixing of a bowstring: Too high, lower it; Too low, lift it. More than enough, reduce it; Not enough, replenish it. Therefore, heaven's Tao Takes from those who have more than enough To replenish those who do not have enough; Man's way	Is not the way of heaven like the stretching of a bow? The high it presses down, The low it lifts up; The excessive it takes from, The deficient it gives to. It is the way of heaven to take from what has in excess in order to make good what is deficient. The way of man is otherwise: it takes from those who are in want in order	Heaven's Reason Is not Heaven's Reason truly like stretching a bow? The high it brings down, the lowly it lifts up. Those who have abundance it depleteth; those who are deficient it augmenteth. Such is Heaven's Reason. It depleteth those who have abundance but completeth the deficient. Man's Reason is not so.	The cosmos's Direction is like extending a bow. Aiming too high, it lowers; aiming too low, it raises. From the excessive, it takes; to the insufficient, it augments. The cosmos's Direction is to take from the excessive and augment the insufficient. This is not so for
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is to reduce what is deficient And to supplement what is overfull. Who can supplement the overfull for the people of the world? Only the man of Tao can do it. Therefore, with the wise, work is done and no one depends on it. Achievements are made, but no one claims credit. Is he not free from wishing to show off his superiority?	do not have enough To offer to those who have more than enough. Who can, having more than enough, Offer some to heaven? Perhaps only those who possess the Tao. Hence, the sage man Helped without possessing, Scored merits without claiming. That is how He did not wish to parade his worth.	to offer this to those who already have more than enough. Who is there that can take what he himself has in excess and offer this to the empire? Only he who has the way. Therefore the sage benefits them yet exacts no gratitude, Accomplishes his task yet lays claim to no merit. Is this not because he does not wish to be considered a better man than others?	He depleteth the deficient in order to serve those who have abundance. Where is he who would have abundance for serving the world? Indeed, it is the holy man who acts but claims not; merit he acquires but he does not dwell upon it, and does he ever show any anxiety to display his excellence?	the direction in humans, which is to take from the insufficient to augment the excessive. Who is willing to augment [the insufficient of] the world with excesses? Only ones with Direction. Thus, a sage provides without expecting approbation, accomplishes without seeking acclamation, does without flaunting wisdom.
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Water is the softest
and meekest thing in
the world,

Yet it is best able to
overcome that which
is strong and solid.

This is the truth and
cannot be changed.

"The meek
suppresses the solid,
the soft suppresses
the strong."

All the people in the
world know this,

Yet they

Nothing under
heaven is softer and
weaker than water,

Yet, in attacking the
hard and strong,

Nothing can surpass
it,

Because nothing can
replace it.

That the soft
overcome the hard,

And the weak
overcome the strong
-

None under heaven
does

In the world there is
nothing more
submissive and weak
than water.

Yet for attacking that
which is hard and
strong nothing can
surpass it.

This is because there
is nothing that can
take its place.

That the weak
overcomes the
strong,

And the submissive
overcomes the hard,

Everyone in the
world knows yet no
one can put

Trust in Faith

In the world nothing
is tenderer and more
delicate than water.
In attacking the hard
and the strong
nothing will surpass
it. There is nothing
that herein takes its
place.

The weak conquer
the strong, the tender
conquer the rigid.

In the world, nothing
is softer and weaker
than water, yet, in
combating the strong,
nothing can win over
it.

There is nothing to
replace it.

The weak wins over
the strong; the tender
wins over the steely.

No one in the

cannot apply it to
their lives.

Therefore, the wise
says:

"Those who can
accept the blame for
the entire nation

Will be the leaders of
the nation.

Those who can
endure the evil
omens of the world

Will be the kings of
the world."

Right expression is
similar to its reversal.

not know it,

Yet none can practice
it.

Hence, the sage
man's saying goes:

"He who bears the
state's humiliations

Is called lord of the
land;

He who bears the
state's calamities

Is called king of the
empire."

A positive statement
sounds paradoxical.

this knowledge into
practice.

Therefore the sage
says,

One who takes on
himself the
humiliation of the
state

Is called a ruler
worthy of offering
sacrifices to the gods
of earth and millet.

One who takes on
himself the calamity
of the state

Is called a king
worthy of dominion
over the entire
empire.

In the world there is
no one who does not
know it, but no one
will practise it.

Therefore the holy
man says:

"Him who the
country's sin makes
his,

We hail as priest at
the great sacrifice.

Him who the curse
bears of the country's
failing.

As king of the empire
we are hailing."

True words seem
paradoxical.

world is unaware of
it, yet no one follows
it.

Thus, the sage says:

"One accepting a
state's disgrace is
worthy of being her
governor;

one accepting the
state's misfortunes is
worthy of being the
king to the world."

Rightful words
appear paradoxical.

When a serious
resentment is
reconciled,
Some resentment
certainly remains.
Thus, reconciliation
cannot be considered
the best way.
Although the wise
holds to the contract
prepared by the
debtor,
He never forces the
debtor to fulfill

In pacifying a great
enmity,
There must be some
remnant enmity.
How could that be
considered good?
Hence, the sage man
Held the left half of
the deed

When peace is made
between great
enemies,
Some enmity is
bound to remain
undispelled.
How can this be
considered perfect?
Therefore the sage
takes the left-hand
tally, but exacts no
payment from the
people.
The man

Keep Your
Obligations
When a great hatred
is reconciled,
naturally some hatred
will remain. How can
this be made good?
Therefore the sage
keeps the obligations
of his contract and
exact not from
others.

Settling a major
enmity, residual
enmity remains.
Responding enmity
with virtue - how can
this be good?
Thus, the sage holds
the left half [of a
promissory block]
but does not demand

his responsibility.
Therefore, the man of
Tê holds only to the
contract,
While the man
without Tê presses
for taxes.
The way of nature is
free from intimacy.
Yet it constantly
stays with the good
man.

Without demanding
payment from the
people.
Therefore, those who
possess virtue
administer deeds;
Those who possess
no virtue administer
tithing.
Heaven's Tao is
unbiased;
It always supports
good men.

of virtue takes charge
of the tally;
The man of no virtue
takes charge of
exaction.
It is the way of
heaven to show no
favoritism.
It is for ever on the
side of the good man.

Those who have
virtue attend to their
obligations; those
who have no virtue
attend to their claims.
Heaven's Reason
shows no preference
but always assists the
good man.

payment.
One with virtue acts
like that creditor;
one without virtue
acts like the tax
collector.
The cosmos's
Direction does not
play favoritism.
It [simply] provides
people with goodness
all the time.

There is a kingdom which is small and sparsely populated. There are numerous implements, but no one uses them. The people love their lives and no one wants to move afar. Boats and carriages are available, but no one rides them. Fine weapons are in their possession, but no one uses them. The people are back in the times	A small state with few people: Let there be utensils ten, A hundred times its population Without being used; Let the people take death seriously, And stay away from migration; Let there be boats and carriages With no occasion to ride them; Let there be armor and weapons With no occasion to display them; Let the sovereign	Reduce the size of the population and the state. Ensure that even though the people have tools of war for a troop or a battalion they will not use them; And also that they will be reluctant to move to distant places because they look on death as no light matter. Even when they have ships and carts, they will have no use for them; And even when they have armor and weapons, they will have no occasion to make a show of them.	Remaining in Isolation In a small country with few people let there be aldermen and mayors who are possessed of power over men but would not use it. Induce people to grieve at death but do not cause them to move to a distance. Although they had ships and carriages, they should find no occasion to ride in them. Although they had armours and weapons, they should find no occasion to don them. 2	Small states. Few people. All sorts of utensils, not in use. The populace value death, unwilling to move. Vehicles available, not in use. Weaponry available, not on display. Tying
when knotted cords were used to record things. They enjoy fine delicacies and are handsome in their dress. They are happy with their residences and are pleased with their traditions. Although the next state is within sight, and the sounds of cocks crowing and dogs barking are heard, The people live their whole lives without traveling to and fro.	revert to tying knots With a rope and put it to use. Make their food delicious, Their clothes beautiful, Their customs joyous, Their habitations comfortable. Neighboring states may be within sight of each other, And sounds of roosters and dogs within hearing, Yet the people, to their old age and death, Never come and go visiting one another.	Bring it about that the people will return to the use of the knotted rope, Will find relish in their food And beauty in their clothes, Will be content in their abode And happy in the way they live. Though adjoining states are within sight of one another, And the sound of dogs barking and cocks crowing in one state can be heard in another, yet the people of one state will grow old and die without having had any dealings with those of another.	Induce people to return to [the old custom of] knotted cords and to use them [in the place of writing], to delight in their food, to be proud of their clothes, to be content with their homes, and to rejoice in their customs: then in a neighboring state within sight, the voices of the cocks and dogs would be within hearing, yet the people might grow old and die before they visited one another.	knots for events. Superbly governed. Well fed, beautifully clad, serenely housed, happily serenad'd. Neighboring states within sights. Crowing and barking heard across states. From birth to death, no interstate communication.

When words express truth, they are not refined. When words are refined, they do not express truth. One who is proficient does not depend on verbal disputation. One who depends on verbal disputation is not proficient. One who knows is not encyclopedic. One who is encyclopedic does not know. The wise	Truthful words are not beautiful; Beautiful words are not truthful. He who knows is not widely informed; He who is widely informed does not know. He who is good does not have much; He who has much is	Truthful words are not beautiful; Beautiful words are not truthful. Good words are not persuasive; Persuasive words are not good. He who knows has no wide learning; He who has wide learning does not know. The sage does not hoard. Having	Propounding the Essential True words are not pleasant; pleasant words are not true. The good are not contentious; the contentious are not good. The wise are not learned; the learned are not wise. The holy man hoards not.	Sincere words are not pretty; pretty words are not sincere. Good people are not argumentative; argumentative people are not good. Learned people are not erudite; erudite people are not learned. A sage does not hoard. The
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does not accumulate. The more he works for other people, the more he gains. The more he shares with other people, the more he receives. The Tao followed by heaven is to do good and not to harm. The Tao followed by the wise is to work and not to claim credit.	not good. The sage man did not accumulate, Exhausting himself to help the people, He was fuller; Exhausting himself to give the people, He was richer. Therefore, heaven's Tao Benefits without harming; Man's Tao Assists without contending. []	bestowed all he has on others, he has yet more; Having given all he has to others, he is richer still. The way of heaven benefits and does not harm; The way of the sage is bountiful and does not contend.	The more he does for others, the more he owns himself. The more he gives to others, the more will he himself lay up an abundance. Heaven's Reason is to benefit but not to injure; the holy man's Reason is to accomplish but not to strive. []	more he/she provides, the more he/she is enriched; the more he/she gives, the more he/she gains. The cosmos's Direction is to facilitate and not harm; The sage's Direction is to provide and not compete. []
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